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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

Implementation of federalism discussed with Chief Ministers

PM points out coordination challenges between 3-tier governments

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathamandu, Feb. 8



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' addressing a meeting of the Council of Ministers with Chief Ministers of all seven provinces in Singha Durbar, Kathmandu on Thursday.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' discussed strengthening the implementation of federalism with the leaders of the ruling coalition and provincial chief ministers.

During a meeting held at the residence of the Prime Minister, Baluwatar on Thursday, Prime Minister Prachanda discussed the challenges seen in the coordination between federal, provincial and local level for the effective implementation of federalism and its solution.

Nepali Congress President Sher Bahadur Deuba, NC Vice President and Deputy Prime Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka, CPN (Maoist Centre) Deputy General Secretary Barshaman Pun, CPN (Unified Socialist) Chair Madhav Kumar Nepal and leaders from the Janata Samajbadi Party, the Democratic Socialist Party and the Nagarik Unmukti Party were present at the meeting.

Chief ministers of all seven provinces arrived in Kathmandu to attend the second meeting of the National Coordination Council.

Meanwhile, at a meeting held between the Prime Minister, members of the Council of the Ministers and chief ministers of all seven provinces at Singha Durbar, Prime Minister said he would address the concerns expressed by chief ministers on the implementation of the federalism.

He said, "The effective implementation of federalism is a shared responsibility for all of us. You have understood the concerns of the chief ministers. Take it seriously."

Stating that active participation of chief ministers would contribute in the implementation of federalism, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the government led by him had accorded utmost priority to the implementation of federalism.

Gandaki Province Chief Minister Surendra Raj Pandey pointed out that the initiatives form the Prime Minister in implementing federalism should be taken seriously and federal ministers and parliament members should also be equally responsible for it. He thanked the Prime Minister for his initiation taken for the operation of Korala border and also drew attention of Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport for quick construction of the Mugling-Pokhara and Narayangadh-Butwal highways.

Madhes Province Chief Minister Saroj Kumar Yadav urged Finance Ministry for the operation of the chhoti customs office, connected with Indian border. Stating that the province faced severe problems of irrigation and drinking water, he said that the federal government should take the lead in resolving these issues. He said, "Let's begin irrigation projects in partnership of federal government and province and increase production in Tarai-Madhes."

Karnali Province Chief Minister Raj Kumar Sharma stressed on the need to review the delays observed in the implementation of federalism. He said that the province still faced problems of electrification, proper irrigation facilities and communication sectors.

Chief Minister of Sudurpaschim Province Kamal Bahadur Shah appreciated the initiative taken by the Prime Minister in implementing federalism and urged federal ministers to also advance in the same direction. He stressed the need for a centralised mindset to be responsible for the slow progress in implementing federalism. He said, "An important agreement has been reached for the development of Sudurpaschim during the Prime Minister's visit to India. Development in Sudurpaschim is a priority of this government. I thank the Prime Minister."

Chief Minister of Bagmati Province Shalikram Jamkattel said that the federal ministries should immediately transfer the authorities. He said, "It takes time to transfer the rights by formulating laws but there should be no delay in making decisions."

Lumbini Province Chief Minister Dilli Bahadur Chaudhary said that federal ministers should admire the steps taken by the Prime Minister in implementing federalism. He said, "We brought the federalism, we need to show ownership in implementing it. The forces who worked for drawing constitution should also work for the implementation of federalism."

Koshi Province Chief Minister Kedar Karki said that federal ministers should also understand the sentiments of the Prime Minister in the implementation of federalism. He said, "Federal ministers should let us know what they are doing for the implementation of federalism. Federal ministers should not delay in transferring powers to the lower level."

New budget will put people's needs in priority: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 8

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the budget for the upcoming fiscal year should be prepared keeping in mind the priorities of the state and the future of the people.

During a meeting on the 'national resources estimation for coming fiscal year 2024/25' held at Singha Durbar on Thursday, Prime Minister Prachanda emphasised the need to set the budget ceiling by keeping the people at the centre.

He instructed the ministries to select the plans for the next fiscal year by giving special priority to the plans that increase production and create jobs.

"Let's be realistic while preparing the budget. Let's think about managing resources by being 'proactive," Prime Minister Prachanda said, "Our policies and programmes and budget should win the trust of the people. The system should be strengthened."

Stating that the budget is not only purely economics but also political economics, the Prime Minister stressed the need to move forward to end the disagreements that happened in the past year. He said, "In the past, there was some confusion between the National Planning Commission and the Ministry, the Ministry of Finance and the Nepal Rastra Bank. This should not happen now."

Stating that the country's economy has been moving in the right direction recently, Prime Minister Prachanda said, "After continuous efforts, the revenue mobilisation has increased and the indicators of the external sector of the economy have improved significantly."

Emphasising that the fiscal and monetary policy should be determined after identifying the reasons for the non-increase in capital expenditure, he said, "Let's make a budget based on national importance and priorities. Let's seriously review why the capital expenditure has not been increased and prepare a budget accordingly."

On that occasion, Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat said that a balanced and realistic budget was necessary in a situation where there is a contradiction between demand and capacity.

Stating that there was no reduction in revenue collection this fiscal year compared to the previous year, he said, "Revenue has increased by 10 per cent. Internationally, this is considered a good progress."

Vice Chairman of the National Planning Commission Dr. Min Bahadur Shrestha informed about the scenario of sources of the budget, revenue, grants, foreign debt and domestic borrowing. Ministers and secretaries of various ministries participated in the discussion.

Govt firm to punish the corrupt: DPM Shrestha

BY RABINDRA UPRETI
Bardibas, Feb. 8



DPM Narayan Kaji Shrestha

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha has said that the government will not take a rest from the campaign to maintain zero tolerance for corruption.

DPM Shrestha stated that the main reason behind the country's backwardness was bad governance and corruption and claimed that the government had taken effective steps to control it and establish good governance.

DPM Shrestha made this remark while addressing a function organised at Gauridanda, Bardibas 3, Mahottari on Thursday.

The Minister for Home Affairs said there was an increasing danger that development and prosperity would be limited to tall talks until good governance was maintained by effectively controlling corruption.

"I want to reassure you all that those who loot and embezzle the state will be prosecuted sooner or later and for that, the government is ready to face any situation," DPM Shrestha expressed his determination.

At the same time, in cases such as fake Bhutanese refugees, Lalita Niwas and the gold smuggling scandal, action was initiated against those who cheated the state, and the campaign was launched to recover the looted state property, he said.

He said that strict action has been taken against the embezzlers of 10 ropanis of the land of Bansbari Leather Shoe Factory in the part of the government campaign.

The government has begun the process from the concerned department to scrap the decision made to transfer the 10 ropanis of land of Bansbari and for this 21 days of notice to begin the process has also begun, said DPM Shrestha.

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GOVT ANNULS 1,636 VACANCIES OF POSTAL SERVICE

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 8

The government has scrapped 1,636 vacancies of different posts under the Postal Service of the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology. A meeting of the Council of Ministers held in Singha Durbar on Thursday took the decision to this effect, according to Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma.

» CABINET DECISIONS

Minister Sharma, who is also the spokesperson for the government, said that the Cabinet meeting decided to change the organisational structure of the Department of Postal Service to implement the concept of one postal office in one local levels.

Minister Sharma said that the Cabinet meeting has also decided to scrap the Office of Central Money Order and Philatelic and Postal Stamps Management Office under the Department of Postal Service.

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Today's Supplement Highlight

Balance wildlife and human needs.



Investment policy reform discussed

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 8

A meeting of the Steering Committee of the third Nepal Investment Summit (NIS) has discussed the reports and projects related to policies, laws and structural reforms prepared in view of the summit.

Speaking at the meeting held on Thursday, Minister of Finance and Coordinator of the Committee, Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat, said that international investors are getting interested to invest in Nepal and instructed the concerned authorities to prepare projects seriously.

"There is an unprecedented opportunity for us to attract investment, so the government will leave no stone unturned in legal and policy reforms to attract foreign as well as Nepali investors and non-resident Nepalis," he said.

The main goal of the investment conference is to convey the message that Nepal is an excellent investment destination to the world community.

Ek Narayan Aryal, Coordinator of the Policy, Law and Structural Reform Working Group and Secretary of the Prime Minister's Office, presented a report on legal and policy reforms which included the inputs received in the meeting of the Investment Conference Implementation Committee chaired by the Chief Secretary. According to him, a bill to amend some Nepal Acts to facilitate investment would enter the parliamentary process soon.

The task force aims to remove the legal and policy obstacles in industry, business and investment sectors and to remove the difficulties and delays experienced in the implementation of construction projects.

For the same, amendments are proposed in the laws related to national parks and wildlife reserve, land and land acquisition, environment protection, electronic transactions, civil aviation, and foreign investment and technology transfer.

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Bridge found being constructed far away from designated site

BY NAVARAJ KATTEL
Biratnagar, Feb. 8

Almost seven years after the construction began, an under-construction bridge was found but in a different location in Sunsari.

Constructed under the Sunsari-Morang Bridge Project, the bridge was unexpectedly found in a different area within Barju Rural Municipality, Sunsari.

The Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport started the construction of the Sunsari-Morang Bridge Project in 2017/2018. Shankaramali Kirateswar J.V. Koteshwor was awarded a contract for the construction of the project at Rs. 61.8 million.

The ministry had instructed the construction company to build the bridge over the Tengra River in the area that falls in the erstwhile Amaduwa Village Development Committee's Ward Nos. 5 and 8. The area now falls under Barju Rural Municipality-4.

However, the bridge was discovered being constructed at Pasaman Tole of Sitagunj, which falls within Ward No. 7 of the former Amahibella Village Development Committee in Sunsari, as well as Ward No. 5 of the Ramganj Belgachhia Rural Municipality. The location where the bridge is being constructed currently lies within Ward No. 5 and 2 of Barju Rural Municipality.

The plan for the construction of the bridge was designated over the Tengra River in Barju Rural Municipality 4. However, it has been discovered that the budget allocated for the purpose has been misused, resulting in the construction of the bridge at a different location from the previously designated site.

The local authorities expressed concern upon discovering the construction of the bridge in a different location.

Jibachhu Kumar Rai, Chairman of Barju Rural Municipality, has informed that the ministry has been formally notified to construct the bridge in the place where it was originally designated with the allocated budget after Rs. 8.93 million was allocated for the bridge in the current fiscal year.

All infrastructure projects under the Bridge Construction Project have now been transferred to the Road Division Office in Biratnagar.



Rajendra Prasad Sah, Head of the Road Division Office, said that upon investigation, it was discovered that the construction of the bridge was carried out at a different location from one initially specified.

The Road Division Office in Biratnagar conducted on-site monitoring. "We have identified an error in the construction site, and we will take steps to rectify it," Sah said.

As the bridge was constructed away from the original location after the budget was released, the only option is to revise the location and ensure its proper implementation, he added.

The construction company has also delayed completing the bridge. Although the construction of the bridge was mandated to begin in 2017, only 65 per cent of the work has been completed so far, but the construction company has already received 60 per cent payment, amounting to Rs. 33.2 million.

The final payment of the bridge being constructed by Shankaramali Kirateswar JV under the contract of 'SMBCP-16-073-074' was revoked on June 28, 2021. After that, the construction company did not return to the construction site.

Sah said that he has been in regular contact with the construction company to ensure the implementation of the work using the allocated budget of Rs. 8.9 million for the current fiscal year. He also said that the construction company has been requested to complete the bridge at its current location, and discussions are underway to incorporate a new plan where necessary.

Anil Mandal, representative of the construction company, said that construction work was halted last year due to the need to revise the bridge design. Although the length specified in the Detailed Project Report (DPR) was 35 metres, it has been adjusted to 36 metres to align with field observations and requirements.

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IT development is instrumental for good governance: Minister Sharma

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 8

Minister for Communications and Information Technology, Rekha Sharma, has advocated for utilising information technology as the basis of good governance and prosperity.

Inaugurating the 29th CAN Infotech organised by the Computer Association of Nepal (CAN) Federation on Thursday, the Minister said the government acknowledged information technology as a basic need of the citizens as well as a national priority.

Asserting that IT development is essential for achieving prosperity, the government Spokesperson expressed hope that the implementation of the digital Nepal framework would contribute significantly to IT-based progress.

She underscored the government's commitment to establishing good governance, social justice, and prosperity as top national priorities, with the 16th periodic plan prioritising the enhancement of information technology.

Sharma added the development of IT would create job opportunities, serving as a deterrent to the migration of youths seeking employment abroad. She urged the CAN Federation to explore additional service areas, insisting on the importance of public-private cooperation for promoting the IT sector.

The Minister stressed the need for substantial investment in the IT sector, describing it as a tool to strengthen the nation's economy.



PHOTO: KAVIN ADHIKARI\ TRN

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma inaugurating '29th CAN Infotech' organised by Computer Association Nepal (CAN) Federation on Thursday.

Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) President Rajesh Agrawal talked about the need for policy and legal stability to encourage potential investors in Nepal.

Rajendra Malla, President of the Nepal Chamber of Commerce, asserted that the nation's development depends on the IT sector's growth, urging the government to take measures to position Nepal as an 'IT hub.'

CAN Federation President Ranjeet Kumar Poddar said Nepal has already launched the exports of IT services and this should be the priority of the State.

The Infotech, featuring over 150 stalls, is expected to attract 350,000 visitors.

Nepal to showcase ready-made garments in US fashion fair

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 8

A 6-member delegation led by Pashupati Dev Pandey, President of the Garment Association of Nepal is scheduled to participate at the 'Sourcing at Magic' fair to be held in Las Vegas, USA, from February 13 to 15.

Trade and Export Promotion Centre (TEPC) will also participate in this fair as a representative of the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies of the Government of Nepal.

The fair is considered as the most comprehensive fashion marketplace in the US to showcase apparel, footwear, accessories and sourcing resources from around the world.

Pandey is representing Pure Clothing at the fair while others include Basant Raj Adhikari of Himalayan Cotton and Fashion International Pvt. Ltd., Thomnath Basyal of United Fashion and Knitting Pvt. Ltd., Shiva Prasad Bhatta of Shivshakti Garment Pvt. Ltd., Suresh Man Shrestha of Jamfa Knitting Industries Pvt. Ltd., and Ganesh Raj Pandey of Setidevi Export and Import Pvt. Ltd.

Nepali delegation will display Nepali ready-made dresses produced by their respective industries. It is expected that the association's participation in the fair, which is considered important in the world fashion market, will help to promote the market of the Nepali ready-made clothing industry, Pandey



said at a press conference organised by GAN on Thursday.

The fair will help identify possible additional markets through the actions of conducting meetings with other external buyers present at the fair.

The US was the largest market for Nepali garments with about US$ 400 million annual export in 2001/02 but it has come down to about $70 million now.

Implementation of Multi-Fibre Agreement with the USA boosted the export of Nepali garments there.

To revive the industry again, GAN suggested the government simplify the process of cash incentives on exports, provide a 5 per cent subsidy on the interest rate of loans mobilised to the industry, invest in skill development training, and implement the national payment gateway at the earliest.

NEPSE posts 29.3 points growth this week



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 8

The benchmark of the stock market, NEPSE, increased marginally on Thursday, the last transaction day of the week.

The index increased by 5.68 points (0.27 per cent) to close at 2,096.32 points on Thursday.

The sensitive index which measures the performance of group 'A' companies increased by 0.67 points (0.17 per cent) to close at 378.64 points.

The NEPSE index has increased by 29.3 points over the week. The NEPSE index has posted a growth of 14.57 points on Monday, 9.44 points on Tuesday and 4.92 points on Wednesday.

However, the index declined by 5.31 points on Sunday.

A total of 9,171,710 shares worth Rs. 3.21 billion of 317 companies were sold in 67,273 transactions today.

The sub-indices of all groups, except banking, others and mutual funds increased in today's transactions.

Sub-index of the non-life insurance group saw the highest growth of 42.25 points followed by the hydropower and microfinance group whose indices increased by 37.51 points and 31.71 points respectively.

Similarly, the development bank group sub-index increased by 25.99 points, life insurance by 20.78 points, hotels and tourism by 20.06 points and manufacturing and processing by 15.64 points.

Sub-index of finance increased by 3.29 points, trading by 3.29 points, and the investment group by 0.12 points.

However, the sub-index of other group decreased by 11.94 points, banking by 0.56 points and mutual fund by 0.18 points today.

Share prices of Samaj Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha increased by 10 per cent, Buddha Bhumi Nepal Hydropower Company by 9.99 per cent, Trishuli Jal Vidhyut Company by 9.84 per cent and Maya Khola Hydropower Company by 7.78 per cent.

However, share prices of Siddhartha Investment Growth Scheme 3 decreased by 9.97 per cent, RBB Mutual Fund 1 by 5.53 per cent and Ganapati Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha by 3.66 per cent.

DISNEY TO INVEST $1.5 BILLION TO CREATE GAMES, ENTERTAINMENT

AP
Burbank, Calif., Feb. 8

The Walt Disney Co. said Wednesday it is paying $1.5 billion for a stake in "Fortnite" maker Epic Games, working with the game developer to create a "games and entertainment universe" that will feature games, shows and characters from Disney, Pixar, Marvel, Star Wars, Avatar and more.

"This marks Disney's biggest entry ever into the world of games and offers significant opportunities for growth and expansion," Disney CEO Bob Iger said in a statement.

Disney said the two companies have already collaborated on "Fortnite" content, including the Marvel "Nexus War with Galactus," which drew more than 15.3 million concurrent players.

Nepali, German business leaders sign collaboration deal

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 8

The Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI) and the Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) signed separate Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs) with the German Association for Small and Medium-Sized Businesses (BVMW) on Wednesday to explore the possibility of German companies investing in Nepal or collaborating with Nepali businesses.

The MOUs were signed by FNCCI President Chandra Prasad Dhakal, President of CNI, Rajesh Kumar Agrawal and Christoph Ahlhaus, Executive Chairman of BVMW, on behalf of their respective organizations.

The MOU signing ceremony was held at the Embassy of Germany in Kathmandu in the presence of German Ambassador to Nepal, Dr. Thomas Prinz.

Dhakal said that there needs to be collaboration between FNCCI and BVMW to promote trade relations between Nepal and Germany. He added that both the organisations need to explore ways to increase exports from Nepal to Germany because Germany has been a trusted export destination for Nepal for many decades, according to a statement issued by the FNCCI.

He also mentioned that SMEs will be affected by Nepal's graduation to a developing country status the most as Nepal will lose the facility of duty-free access for exports to Europe. He stressed that SMEs, particularly run by women, need to be supported. He added FNCCI and BVMW should collaborate for the promotion and development of SMEs.

Likewise, CNI informed that Agrawal underscored the potential of the MoU to strengthen ties between the SME sector of Nepal and Germany. He highlighted the promise it holds for Nepal's SMEs, envisioning a future where collaboration between Nepali and German SMEs leads to mutual growth and prosperity.

Ambassador Prinz expressed his optimism about the pivotal role the MoUs will play in facilitating the exchange of business opportunities and investments, particularly in sectors such as AI and IT. He emphasized the significance of this partnership in transcending borders and fostering cooperation between SMEs of both nations.

Shubhashish Thapaliya, Nepal's representative for BVMW, said that the MoU aims to enhance trade relations, attract investments, and explore avenues for joint ventures beneficial to both nations.

The major objectives of the MOU are to enhance cooperation between FNCCI and CNI and BVMW and establish a practical framework to cooperate in investment promotion. The MOU also speaks about strengthening institutional relations and capacity building through mutual cooperation.

As per the MOU, both FNCCI and BVMW will have a regular exchange of information on investment policies, rules, regulations, procedures, incentives and opportunities. There will also be an exchange of general updates on statistics and data related to Nepal and Germany to make them accessible to both organizations.

Market to be monitored to check substandard food items

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Waling, Feb. 8

The municipalities of Syangja have committed to cooperating with market monitoring, regulation and management of food items that lack quality standards and control packed food items without proper labelling and adulterated food.

During a programme organised by the Food Technology and Quality Control Office, Pokhara, in Waling of Syangja, deputy mayors of all the 11 local governments of the district said that they would cooperate for effective market monitoring in the district.

The transportation of food items falling behind quality standards set by the government via highway can be checked if the authorities in all municipalities are attentive.

Kabita Tiwari Gaire, Deputy Mayor of Waling Municipality, said that the responsibility of market monitoring has been given to the local level, and cooperation among all municipalities would help control the selling of adulterated items.

She said that it was their job to make citizens responsible for food hygiene and quality.



PHOTO: TRN

Deputy heads local governments of Syangja at a programme organised by Food Technology and Quality Control Office, Pokhara, at Waling Syangja.

Tiwari said, "Traders should be held responsible and citizens should be aware of the food they are consuming."

Speaking at the programme, Food Research Officer Bijan Shrestha said that as market monitoring was weak, citizens were consuming adulterated food.

He said, "It is a must to control the distribution of unhealthy foods items by strengthening the market monitoring activities, as the health of the citizens is all that matters."

According to Shrestha, there is no good agricultural production practice and expired and inedible food products are found almost everywhere in the market.

He said that it would be easier to manage and regulate the market if the local bodies used their authority in market monitoring and taking action against offenders.

Deputy Chief of District Coordination Committee Syangja Khadka Raj Subedi, chief of Area Administration Office, Waling Ghanashyam Gautam and others said that they would work together with the municipality for market monitoring and regulation to ensure that consumers are not cheated and they get to buy the quality products.

Japan's Honda reports its profit rose

AP
Tokyo, Feb. 8

Japanese automaker Honda's profit rose 3.5% in the October-December quarter from a year earlier on the back of solid demand in the U.S. and Europe and a recovery in its home market, the company said Thursday.

Tokyo-based Honda Motor Co.'s profit in the last quarter was 253.3 billion yen, or $1.7 billion. Quarterly sales jumped 21% to 5.39 trillion yen ($36 billion).

A favorable exchange rate helped amplify Honda's overseas profits in yen terms and is expected to continue through the rest of the fiscal year, which ends in March. The dollar has been trading at about 148 Japanese yen, up from about 140 yen last year.

All the automakers have been hurt by shortages of computer chips and other parts, partly due to disruptions in manufacturing because of the coronavirus pandemic. The latest results show Honda has mostly but not yet fully recovered to pre-pandemic levels in some locations.

Honda's motorcycle sales grew in recent months in Brazil and Europe, according to the manufacturer of the Fit small car, Super Cub motorcycle and Asimo robot.

Honda said it remained committed to "initiatives toward electrification," pointing to the global electric vehicle concept models shown at the Consumer Electronics Show in Las Vegas, such as the Saloon and Space Hub.



PHOTO: AP

People walk near the logo of Honda Motor Company at a showroom on Feb. 8, 2022, in Tokyo.

Japanese automakers including Honda have lagged in the global push toward pure EVs, partly because of their strength in other green models such as hybrids and fuel cells.

Over the first nine months of the fiscal year, Honda sold 3.1 million vehicles, up from 2.7 million vehicles the previous year, with sales especially strong in the U.S.

A decline in Honda's vehicle sales in Thailand and Indonesia was offset by rising sales in China.

For the full fiscal year through March, Honda is projecting a 960 billion yen ($6.5 billion) profit, up from an earlier forecast for a 930 billion yen ($6.3 billion), and surpassing the 651 billion yen earned the year before.

We'll fulfil public expectations: Mayor Sonar

Jaleshwor is recognised as the first and oldest municipality of Mahottari district. Jaleshwor, previously known as the headquarters of Janakpur region, was declared a municipal panchayat on April 27, 1980. However, the place has not witnessed the expected development.

The Rising Nepal's correspondent **Nagendra Kumar Karna** interviewed Mayor **Suresh Sha Sonar**, elected from the Janata Samajwadi Party Nepal in Jaleshwor Municipality on the development and issues of Jaleshwor. Excerpts:

INTERVIEW



PHOTO: NAGENDRA KUMAR KARNA/TRN

Mayor of Jaleshwor Municipality Suresh Sha Sonar.

You just mentioned about achievements, but what specific works have been done to be proud of?

All the works align with people's expectations. Therefore, all are worthy of pride. However, we have transformed Laxmi Chandi Murarka Secondary School into a model school and resolved the disputes of other schools.

What initiatives have been taken to preserve an identity of Jaleshwor?

We realised the concept of Singha Durbar in every village for easy access of services to people. Based on this, we do not favour shifting district-level offices and former regional offices to the headquarters, which have been in the headquarters from the past.

What challenges hinder meeting public expectations including development?

People's expectations have increased after the introduction of the concept of Singha Durbar in every village. Laws have been formulated, but the federal government still hasn't provided rights to exercise many of them. Therefore, we are unable to meet people's expectations despite willing to do so. Constitutional rights for implementation of federalism should to given to the provincial and local level governments. Then only we can meet people's expectations.

Jaleshwor was named after the Jaleshwor Nath Mahadev sitting in water. What have been done to increase tourist flow to the city?

The Jaleshwor Nath Mahadev temple is a historical religious heritage of Jaleshwor. From the past, efforts have been made to attract tourists to the temple and we continue to do so. We have maintained external beauty of the temple by colouring, lighting and keeping it clean and facilitating people coming there. A grand aarati is held every Monday. Though the temple carries Tereta Era significance, we have promoted it in various media as it is a Jyotirlinga.

What are your future plans?

We will give more priority to agriculture sector. There is a need of sustainable initiatives as we have experienced a scarcity of water during the summer season. For this, we plan to visit wards and identify water problems, study feasibility of irrigation and will come up with necessary solutions.

What are the internal sources and infrastructures of the municipality? How is it being managed?

The municipality has limited internal sources. Tax collection from Ward No. 1 to Ward No. 12, lease of ponds and others are the sources. We don't have other options than to conduct development works from the tax collected despite providing ease to the public in taxes. The budget coming from the federal and provincial levels is also relatively low. The city needs job opportunities, but we are unable to do so due to limited income sources.

How has the management of waste and stray cattle in the municipality been addressed, despite apparent inefficiencies?

In the past, the city experienced severe waste management problems, but the situation is different now since the city dwellers have become aware of the issue. However, the stray cattle problem still exists in the city. Freeing cattle in the morning and evening by their owners have led to many road accidents. It has been challenging despite deploying municipal police. We are planning to build a 'Kanji House' to control stray cattle.

Manipal and dry ports are the plans to transform the city. What initiatives have been taken in this regard?

Manipal and dry ports are the backbone for the development of the area. Manipal College has been a dream of the people for years. We signed an agreement with Manipal a few months ago. Discussions on dry port issues have also been ongoing continuously with the Chief District Officer and other authorities.

Is there anything left to say?

We still have three years left. We are committed to fulfilling public expectations. More than 100,000 people in this area reach Lahan for eye check-ups. We are considering operating an eye hospital in Jaleshwor by coordinating and cooperating with Chaudhary Eye Hospital of Lahan. Jaleshwor Municipality has decided to provide 10 katthas of land near by Malwada Kuti for the eye hospital. We need to be united and think about developing the headquarters and creating employments. The municipality is always ready to provide land and resolve disputes. I want to convey a message to everyone to come together and contribute to the development of the district headquarters by utilising the available resources.

Cyclists from India, China to Join Tour The Thakurdwara



PHOTO: GOVIND SHARMA/TRN

The Nepalgunj Cycling Club organising cycle tour event in Banke, Thursday.

BY GOVIND SHARMA
Banke, Feb. 8

Cyclists from India and China are set to join the Tour The Thakurdwara, scheduled for February 9 to 10 (Friday and Saturday).

According to Satish Niraula, the programme coordinator of the Nepalgunj Cycling Club, more than 200 cyclists will participate in the event.

The Nepalgunj Cycling Club has been organising the cycle tour event for the past six years to promote religious and tourist destinations in Banke and Bardiya districts.

According to Niraula, the journey from Bageshwari temple in Banke to Thakurdwara in Bardiya spans a distance of 104 kilometres.

All necessary preparations for the event have been finalised.

The bike ride will commence from Bageshwari temple, passing through Kohalpur, Bardiya's Kedareshwar Dham, Satkhaluwa and concluding in Thakurdwara temple.

On Friday, the journey will start from Bageshwari in Nepalgunj and will reach various religious and touristic places in Banke and Bardiya to Thakurdwara.

Pradeep Sapkota, the chairman of the organiser Nepalgunj Cycling Club, informed that the cycle journey is helping the business as well as tourism in Banke and Bardiya.

The estimated cost of the event is Rs. 2.7 million this year.

IT'S NOT TIME TO CHANGE PM: CHAIR NEPAL

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb 8

Chairman of CPN (Unified Socialist), Madhav Kumar Nepal, said time has not come to change the prime minister.

At a time when some leaders of Nepali Congress, one of the ruling partners, are speaking about the change of prime minister as per the agreement, Chairman Nepal insisted that Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' should be allowed to continue the job of the Prime Minister.

Talking to media persons after the parliament meeting on Monday, the CPN (Unified Socialist) Chairman viewed, "It is not right time to raise the issue of changing prime minister because the government is poised to prepare annual policy and programmes and budget for the next fiscal year."

US to provide $1.37m for Jajarkot earthquake recovery efforts

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 8

The United States Government through USAID has announced $1.37 million to support recovery efforts following the devastating earthquake in Jajarkot.

The 5.6-magnitude earthquake that struck on November 3, 2023, in Jajarkot and Rukum West districts, claimed the lives of at least 154 people and injured hundreds, as well as damaging and destroying homes and buildings.

This resulted in widespread displacement, disruption of essential services, and urgent needs for shelter, food, clean water, and medical care.

USAID's support, implemented through Save the Children, will help earthquake-affected communities withstand the winter, recover from the destruction caused by the earthquake, and ultimately build back better, according to the US Embassy in Nepal.

Immediately after the earthquake, USAID pivoted existing programmes to provide critically needed relief supplies, water quality kits, and support for physical rehabilitation.

This rapid support was provided in addition to more than $23.3 million USAID invested in disaster risk reduction and resilience in Karnali since 2019, as well as longer-term recovery, reconstruction, and rehabilitation work in the months ahead.

Raskot Municipality to mark Janayuddha Day

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kalikot, Feb. 8

Raskot Municipality in Kalikot district has decided to mark the Janayuddha Day ('People's War' Day) on February 13 even a Supreme Court order has slashed the holiday given on the occasion.

A bench of Justices Ananda Mohan Bhattarai and Mahesh Sharma Paudel of the SC on December 29 had quashed the government's decision to mark the day and give a public holiday on Falgun 1 of the Nepali calendar. A writ against the government's decision was filed by individuals including advocate Gyanendra Raj Aran.

Adhering to the SC's verdict, the Ministry of Home Affairs also issued a public notice notifying the public that the Janayuddha Diwas will not be implemented from now onwards.

But Raskot Municipality defying the order of SC and the notice of the Ministry, has decided to mark the day on February 13 by organising a school-level competition. The Municipality issued the notice in this regard on Thursday.

Janak Raj Neupane, 6th level health officer of the Municipality, said that the Municipality office has decided to mark the day and celebrate the day by organising various functions. "We will mark the day even if there is no public holiday by taking a leave and attending functions," said Neupane.

He said that all the government schools have been informed through a circular to attend the competition being organised by the municipality.

Raskot Municipality's Mayor Dharma Raj Shahi said that the employees who were told to celebrate the Day said that they don't need to follow the court's order.

Mayor Shahi said that since this is a local government with authority, it can decide what to do based on the Local Government Operation Act-2074. Meanwhile, the main opposition party leader of the district and municipal-in-charge of CPN-UML, Bimal Shahi said that it was a matter of shame for the government to disobey the order of the court, saying that the order of the court should be abided by.

TIPPER HITS EX-DSP THAPA TO DEATH IN BARA

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bara, Feb. 8

Former Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) Bishnu Thapa of the National Investigation Department died after being hit by a tipper.

Thapa, who was traveling from Piluwa to Kalaiya on a motorcycle, was hit by a tipper that was heading towards Piluwa from Kalaiya on Wednesday evening at Badharwa Chowk and died in the Kalaiya Provincial Hospital during treatment, police said.

Thapa, a resident of Kalaiya Sub-metropolitan City-7 Barewa, had recently retired from the Department.

The police said that after taking control of the hit-and-run tipper, an extensive search was underway for the absconding driver.

Child rights protection building handed over

BY KEDAR TIMALSINA
Kavrepalanchowk, Feb. 8

A province-level child rights protection building constructed at Gaihrigaun of Panauti Municipality-5 in Kavrepalanchowk district has been handed over to the District Coordination Committee, Kavrepalanchowk.

Minister for Social Development, Bagmati Province, Kumari Moktan handed over the building to District Coordination Chief Deepak Kumar Gautam on Wednesday.

According to the handover letter, the District Coordination Committee will be responsible for the entire ownership, management and operation of the building.

On the occasion, Minister Moktan said that the Ministry and the Committee would jointly formulate a policy for the operation of the building and support keeping orphan children at the newly constructed building.

"We will work by formulating a policy to operate province-level child rights protection building and will work in coordination with all the local levels within the district," he said.

Coordination Chief Gautam said that a separate fund would be established for the operation of the building.

He said that coordination and cooperation between the federal government and local government is a must to bring up orphan children at the building.

The province government had put forward a plan to construct a province-level child rights protection building in the annual program of the fiscal year 2077/78 BS to keep about 100 orphans and helpless children in Bagmati province.



PHOTO: KEDAR TIMALSINA/TRN

The Province-level child rights protection building constructed at Gaihrigaun of Panauti Municipality-5 in Kavrepalanchowk.

Public Works Implementation Unit of Kavrepalanchowk and Joshi, Kunwar UNS JV had signed an agreement for the construction of the building on September 27, 2020.

According to the bilateral agreement, the construction company completed the construction in mid-April 2022.

According to the office, Rs. 51.92 million was spent for the construction of the building, which was contracted for Rs 53.459 million.

Panauti Municipality had provided seven ropanis of land for the construction of the building.

The three-and-a-half-story building has 17 rooms including a multi-purpose assembly hall, library and a kitchen.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

The excellency of every art is its intensity, capable of making all disagreeable evaporate.
-- John Keats

EDITORIAL

Development Fillip

Sluggish pace of development in Nepal has become a perennial problem. One major factor bedeviling our development endeavours is the chronic problem of a meagre capital expenditure. And the problem has become so pervasive that it continues to dampen optimism, contributing to the exodus of youths for foreign employment or for better living standards. In the recent meeting of the House of Representatives (HoR), lawmakers of various political parties expressed their concerns about the frustratingly slow pace of various development projects and the poor capital expenditure and drew the government's attention to the issues that need to be addressed urgently.

Among those featuring prominently were the challenges facing federalism and worrying enlisting of Nepali youths in the Russian Army (RA). Some even went as far as questioning the utility of the provinces, implying that the new exercise in federalism have yielded far fewer results than expected. Amid such accusations and growing frustrations, the government must come up with satisfying answers to silence the mounting criticisms. What drives Nepalis to enroll themselves in the RA when the grave risks are so palpable? If there were plentiful jobs at home paying enough to live a decent life, of course, no one in his/her sane mind would like to go abroad, risking their lives and leaving their family behind.

Why aren't we creating enough jobs? Because abysmally low capital expenditure deprives the economy of the money critical to breathe life into the market. That said, we must appreciate the government's concrete steps to prevent more Nepalis from veering into the harm's way, which seems to have started working. The chorus of calls for the government to bring the remains of the fallen Nepalis in the Russia-Ukraine conflict is getting increasingly louder, so that the families could give them the last final rites to their kin. To prove it's serious about addressing people's urgent issues, the government must show it has left no stone unturned to bring home their mortal remains.

That so many of our countrymen are so desperate to leave for foreign countries hints at the paucity of jobs here and demands measures be taken to stop this. Starting with addressing problems of the construction industry, which has been in the doldrums for long now, can be a step in the right direction. That's crucial because the industrial sector's ability to create jobs is hardly matched by any other. The depth of the problem facing the industry is reflected in the falling demand for cement at a time when cement industry has emerged to be one of our strengths with the achievement of self-sufficiency in its production.

Faced with non-payment issues, several construction companies say they are unable to go ahead with further work for lack of the payment for the work they completed long ago or are staring at bankruptcy. The government must step in to rescue the industry from the brink of collapse and inject a dose of confidence into them. And doing exactly that is easier than many might think. First and foremost, there should be no further delays in paying what is owed to them. Flooding the money into the construction of roads and public structures in decrepit state, which are in dire need of makeover, is the next step that surely works wonders to raise people's confidence in the economy.

Lure More Tourists

BINI DAHAL

There was a time when I felt Nepal, as a tourist destination, was not recognised much in global platforms. Obviously, people could recognise the country as the Everest nation and that was it. However, with passing times, Nepal is gaining wider popularity around the world. It has become a favourite destination for many tourists. For instance, Tripadvisor has declared Kathmandu as the best travel destination for the year 2024. Likewise, the New York Times (NYT) has listed Mustang as a must-see location in its list of 52 must-visit destinations.

Nepal's natural beauty is unparalleled and we take pride in our tourism sector. Every successive government is found doing something to increase the inflow of tourists into in the country. A large number of people and their livelihood is heavily dependent on this smokeless industry. In 2023, the nation welcomed more than a million foreign tourists. According to the Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB), in the first six months of the current fiscal year (2080/81 B.S.), the country was able to earn about Rs. 39.8 billion from the tourism sector. This amount is a 44 per cent increase compared to the same period in fiscal year 2079/80 B.S. It shows that the nation's tourism industry has made a great stride.

When it comes to monitoring the inflow of travellers, we focus on their numbers, their length of stay within the country and their average spending during their stay. The ultimate goal is always about increasing these aspects so as to boost the national economy. Recently, the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation released statistics that the average per tourist spending has increased by US$ four. On average, they spent US$ 44.5 up until Nepali month of Mangsir in 2080 B.S. In 2079 B.S. their average spending stood at US$ 40.5. This indicates that with an increase in the number of tourists in the country, their spending has also gone up.

But the length of stay of tourists does not seem to have improved significantly. In 2023, the average length of stay was 13.4 days. While this is a slight improvement from 2022 when the average length of stay was 13.1 days, the figure is still lower as compared to 2021. In 2021, the average length of stay was 15.5 days. Ensuring that the tourists stay for a longer period of time is key to strengthening the tourism industry. In order to ensure that tourists stay in the country for a longer time, the government authorities and the private sector have to make joint efforts. Tour operators, in collaboration with hotels, airlines and other stakeholders, should come up with more lucrative packages for tourists.

Also, priority must be given to the development of tourism infrastructure. Tourism can only flourish when visitors are prioritised and provided with necessary services. For this, the government should concentrate its efforts on promoting and marketing the country and its unique tourist attractions in the international arena. We have enormous potential for tourism growth. But we should be competitive in prices and offer better accommodation and other facilities to tourists. When branding and services are top-notch, we are able to easily compete in the international market.

Having said this, the existing natural resources will have to be maintained to provide sustainability to the tourism sector. The aforementioned figures should be taken into consideration by the concerned authorities to develop necessary policies and effectively implement them. Because the tourism sector is Nepal's strength, it should be harnessed to the fullest potential.

Navigating Complex Geopolitical Terrains

Dr. Narad Bharadwaj



Foreign policy is not a linear momentum maintained by predictable diplomatic activities. Foreign policy obligations cannot be met by merely following the directive principles of the constitution, policy guidelines enunciated by the foreign ministry and the terms of references provided to the foreign missions. It is something more dynamic process amenable to constantly changing geopolitical realities. Foreign policy is a vast domain of interaction among states eager to protect their national interest and expand the scope of cooperation based partly on long-held theoretical tenets and partly on emerging context of changing international politics. It is a dynamic process driven by a number of constant and variable elements. It is not a stagnant philosophy but a guide to action whose trajectory is shaped by both the durable values and emerging realities.

The constant factors of foreign policy often form the bedrock on the basis of which strategies are formulated to achieve foreign policy goals. These factors are the lodestar which helps a nation to stay in course while navigating the intricate power play of international power players. Foreign policy is anchored on certain abiding principles but it must also always remain responsive to contemporary international dynamics to maintain a steady course through the chaotic landscape of global politics. If we fail to respond to emerging challenges and remain stuck in a rut of conventional notion of meeting routine policy obligations, we will find ourselves on the wrong side of the fence lost and forlorn in the game of winning initiative and score advantage.

Emerging dynamics

Constant factors keep a nation anchored to the vision, mission and general objectives of its foreign policy but they hardly provide capacity to correctly respond to exigencies. We should, therefore, always stay tuned to catch early signals of emerging dynamics. It is the variable factors that waylay us, ensnaring policies into traps and inducing us to take hasty decisions. Variable factors always play critical role in defining foreign policies of a nation. There is more than one element that effects prioritisation of policies. The economic instability, security challenges, climate chance, labour migration, regional and global conflict, obstruction in trade and emerging power alignment are some of the variable factors that play crucial role in prioritising foreign policy responses. It is always important to remain watchful and vigilant to detect the shifts in these variables in order to be able to make correct decisions.

There is a tendency among the poor and developing countries to remain indifferent to emerging fault-lines in the geopolitics and react in haste when crises emerge without weighing in the repercussions and long-term consequences. In order to be in a position to take prudent decision in times of emergency, governments must remain receptive and anticipate situations that may impinge on their economic interests or pose security challenges. In the present day inter-connected world, global issues cannot be viewed in isolation. Climate change in one region may inevitably affect the life of the people in another place, hindering their access to water, food and other resources.

Governments can help communities to make more resilient and better prepared to organise a flexible responses to emerging issues by remaining watchful to changing context. If evolving crisis scenarios are under our radar, we will not be taken off guard and find ourselves in a position to formulate coping strategies. We are living in a world marked by multipolarity with a number of aspirant superpowers competing with each other for expanding sphere of influence, power dominance or control over critical economic resources. Various conflict hotspots have emerged in the world. Russia-Ukraine conflict is on the brink of spilling over Europe with devastating consequences. The Israel-Hamas war is threatening to escalate into a multipronged war involving various ethnic, religious and geopolitical rivals.

> It is not a stagnant philosophy but a guide to action whose trajectory is shaped by both the durable values and emerging realities.

If a major war breaks out in West Asia, which now appears more than likely, many labour source countries of South Asia, South East Asia and Africa including Nepal will be caught into an unprecedented security and economic crisis. There are 2.7 million Nepalis living and working in various West Asian employment destinations. If a regional war breaks out disrupting construction, service industries, production, trade and transport, a great humanitarian crisis may overtake a large migrant population. This scribe remembers the chaotic situation of 2019 /2020 when millions of workers had to be evacuated from the Gulf region to protect them from the disruptive impact of COVID-19 pandemic. About 40,000 Nepali workers had to be evacuated from Qatar alone, 12, 000 through chartered flights and 28,000 through regular flights when international flights resumed.

Clouds of war

Are we prepared to air-lift even one-fourth of the 2.7 million people if widespread war or armed conflict breaks out in the region, which now appears likely? The Houthis have been inflicting an unprecedented disruption in international shipping business by targeting commercial and battle ships in the Red Sea. If the Houthis continue to disrupt international sea transport for a longer period, there will be a global scarcity of essential commodities, inflation will skyrocket and job market will shrink with resultant decline in remittance flow. Have our foreign policy experts anticipated this scenario and warned the government to take proactive steps towards organising response?

Diplomacy, negotiation and dialogue are the cardinal tools for addressing conflict and restoring peace. But the tendency to compete for acquiring cutting-edge weapons and targeting opponents with them has become widespread. The geopolitical landscape is turning ever more dreary and threatening clouds of war are hanging low on the horizon. In this situation, tracking unfolding events and adapting to changing global realities is crucial. Only by staying alert and equipping our institutions with tools of proactive actions can we properly navigate the complex geopolitical terrains of the present day world and make informed and pragmatic decisions to protect our national security and the life of the people caught in unfortunate cycle of international conflict.

(Dr. Bharadwaj is former chairperson of Gorkhapatra Corporation and former ambassador of Nepal to Qatar.bharadwajnaradgmail.com)

Accord Priority To Agriculture Sector

Lok Deep Thapa



There is no doubt that Nepal is an agro-based country. There are hundreds of thousands of people, who not only depend on agriculture for making an income, but also in providing day-to-day staple diet for their families and for themselves to make ends meet. Forget the whole country, but there was a time when even the presently crowded Kathmandu was self-sufficient in basic products like rice, wheat and vegetables. In fact the vegetable products of Kathmandu were taken as a huge delicacy even in the Terai area, considered the food belt of the country and some vegetables were also exported to India.

But now, the tables have turned around and the denizens of Kathmandu have to depend on the imported vegetables from India or China. But they are nowhere in comparison to the vegetables grown in Kathmandu, which old timers here thrived on. It is not only due to the exodus of young workers who have opted to go abroad, but also due to the migration of hundreds of thousands of people who have deserted their villages to come and live here in the capital city. This is not surprising as most facilities that every citizen of the country requires are mostly based here, especially health facilities, educational facilities, job opportunities and also connectivity with other nations of the world.

Manpower

There is no doubt that every Nepali citizen has the right to live in whichever place he or she prefers to live in, but in Kathmandu, it has meant the destruction of the once green fields and also wet lands which made this city a unique part of the country. As we have touched the significance of agriculture in the country, it would not be out of place to also talk about the much needed manpower to make the agriculture sector a strong base. Not only in Kathmandu, where the lush fields have been turned into housing areas, but in many other parts of the country as well, where like mentioned above, many people depended on agriculture to take care of their daily needs, whether in the kitchen or in giving them some sort of an income.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda has said that the government was focused on increasing production and creating employment by developing the agriculture sector. Prime Minister Prachanda revealed that he had studied steps for mechanised agriculture and increased productivity in the agriculture sector during his visits to China and India. He also informed that both the countries had expressed their commitment for the development of agriculture in Nepal. These are all good signs which will benefit Nepal in the long run.

Meanwhile, there is definitely a link between the able-bodied people leaving the country in hordes and at the same time seeing a slump the nation is witnessing in agricultural products. It is not only the shrinking of the fertile land in Kathmandu and other places, but it is also due to both internal migration and those who are seeking better opportunities as well. The fragrant leafy vegetables, equally tasty cucumbers and radishes, besides of course the staple diet of the majority of Nepali people, rice, is a thing of the past now. Now we are seeing the import of poor quality vegetables and also fruits, which we considered healthy food before. Most of the green vegetables and fruits are treated by pesticides which are harmful to the body.

> Artificially grown fruits and the methods used in making them look nice, are actually harmful for any person, forget a person with some sort of ailment.

There are even complaints that green vegetables have been treated through chemical means, as have been fruits, to make them better looking or better tasting, which definitely harms people who consume them. If one goes many decades back in Nepal, it would not be harmful to even just pluck out any green vegetables and eat them raw. They were delicious, they had their own taste and fragrance and they were healthy. But like said before, those days have gone not only due to the shrinking of the fertile lands, but also the massive use of harmful pesticides and other chemicals to make food only look better while it has no nutrient.

The worst part is not only missing the delicious tastes of all these food items of the past, but at the same time being aware that we are eating dangerous food, all in the name of taking care of our health. Once more to go to the past, there was time when people said you had to be severely sick before you could afford to eat fruits. Luckily these days, fruit vendors are seen in every corner of the city. But sadly, whether the fruits are actually good for your body or not, it is difficult to say. Many experts have commented that artificially grown fruits and the methods used in making them look nice, are actually harmful for any person, forget a person with some sort of ailment.

Backbone

But again we have to come back to the issue of how the country can make agriculture a major backbone for hundreds of thousands of people to, if not make gains, then at least to survive. Here, it would not be out of context to say that even those involved in cultivating cash crops, are in dire straits. For example the sugarcane farmers who are suffering because they are not getting enough pay for their produce. It is the same with individuals in the hilly areas growing different fruits and also those who try to make a living by selling milk. These are the problems which the government must address in haste.

Besides sound policies, plans to make agriculture a major source of income would keep many youths back in the country. Providing employment to the citizens, giving them more opportunities and making a leap forward in once again enhancing the agriculture sector would be as important as making much progress in generating more electricity, even for export and promoting tourism, as these all are the pillars which will keep intact the country's economy and also contribute distinctly in maintaining its sovereignty.

(The author is former chief editor of this daily.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 9, 1974

Cold Blooded Murder

Biratnagar, Feb 8: Sudhi and his 18-year old son were murdered cold bloodedly by a gang of dacoits on 28th January, reports RSS

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READER'S MAIL

Support To Vaccinate Stray Dogs

This is in reference to a news report titled "*KMC working to manage 22,000 stray dogs*" published on 8 February, 2024 in your prestigious daily.

According to the news report, the Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) has been consistently working to ensure that the stray dogs are vaccinated.

The rising number of stray dogs have always posed as a major issue for pedestrians and those who are riding a two-wheeler.

There is always a fear of getting chased or attacked.

According to the KMC, there are a total of 22,000 street dogs in the metropolis.

This figure is huge. The authority has been neutering and vaccinating the street dogs.

And personnel have been mobilised in large numbers for the same. The KMC has collaborated with nine different organisations to ensure vaccination for the stray dogs.



The KMC should be appreciated for this move.

Because there is a tendency for many people to just leave their pets on the street.

There is always fear of getting injured and suffering from diseases like rabies from dog bites.

Therefore, the residents should collaborate with the authority and inform them in the case where dogs have not been neutered and vaccinated in their area.

Kriti Dhakal
Tilganga, Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

Once upon a time there was a non-conforming sparrow who decided not to fly south for the winter. However, soon the weather turned so cold that he reluctantly decided to fly south. In a short time ice began to form on his wings and he fell to Earth in a barnyard, nearly frozen solid. A cow passed by where he had fallen, and crapped on the little sparrow. The sparrow thought it was the end, but the manure warmed him and defrosted his wings!

Warm and happy, able to breath, he started to sing. Just then a large cat came by, and hearing the chirping he investigated the sounds. The cat cleared away the manure, found the chirping bird, and promptly ate him. The Moral of the Story:

Everyone who craps on you is not necessarily your enemy Everyone who gets you out of crap is not necessarily your friend.

And if you're warm and happy in a pile of crap, you might just want to keep your mouth shut.

Pakistan votes for new parliament

AP
Islamabad, Feb. 8

Pakistanis braved cold winter weather and sporadic violence to vote for a new parliament Thursday, a day after twin bombings claimed at least 30 lives in the worst election-related violence ahead of the balloting.

Tens of thousands of security forces were deployed at polling stations and authorities suspended mobile phone services across the country to prevent disruptions and flash protests. Pakistan's Interior Ministry said the decision was made to maintain law and order. It did not say when the suspension would be lifted.

There were a handful of attacks that appeared aimed at disrupting the vote.

In the north-western district of Dera Ismail Khan, gunmen set off a bomb and then opened fire at a police van, killing five officers and wounding two others, local police official Khalid Khan said. The officers were assigned to security duty during the elections.

No one claimed responsibility for the attack but the area is a former stronghold of the Pakistani Taliban who often target police forces.

Also in the northwest, gunmen fired on troops in the town of Kot Azam, killing a soldier, police official Fiyyaz Khan said. Again, no one immediately claimed responsibility for that attack.

Unidentified assailants threw hand grenades at two polling stations in restive southwestern Baluchistan province, where twin bombings hit separate election offices on Wednesday, killing at least 30 people and wounding more than two dozen others. The Islamic State group claimed responsibility for both bombings.



PHOTO: AP

Police officers stand guard as people wait their turn to cast their vote at a polling station during the country's parliamentary elections, in Islamabad, Pakistan, Thursday, Feb. 8, 2024.

The grenades on Thursday caused panic among voters but no one was hurt, police said.

Voters headed to the polls in heavy snowfall in the ski resort of Murree, near Islamabad, and lined up to vote in snow-covered plains in eastern Punjab province and the mountains of southern Sindh province.

The election has also been marred by allegations from the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf party of imprisoned former Prime Minister Imran Khan that its candidates were denied a fair chance at campaigning.

The cricket star-turned-Islamist politician — ousted in a no-confidence vote in parliament in 2022 — is behind bars and banned from running in the election. He has a huge following but it's unclear if his angry and disillusioned supporters will turn up at the polls in significant numbers.

Khan's party called the suspension of the mobile phone services "a severe assault on democracy" and a "cowardly attempt by those in power to stifle dissent, manipulate the election's outcome, and infringe upon the rights of the Pakistani people."

The election comes at a critical time for this nuclear-armed nation, an unpredictable Western ally in a region rife with hostile boundaries and tense relations. Pakistan's next government will face huge challenges, from containing unrest, overcoming an intractable economic crisis to stemming illegal migration.

As many as 44 political parties are vying for a share of the 266 seats that are up for grabs in the National Assembly, or the lower house of parliament. An additional 70 seats are reserved for women and minorities in the 336-seat house.

After the election, the new parliament will choose the country's next prime minister. The deep political divisions make a coalition government seem more likely. If no single party wins a simple majority, the first-placed gets a chance to form a coalition government, relying on allies in the house.

The top contender is the Pakistan Muslim League party of three-time former Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif who returned to the country last October after four years of self-imposed exile abroad to avoid serving prison sentences at home. Within weeks of his return, his convictions were overturned, leaving him free to seek a fourth term in office.

After voting in the eastern city of Lahore, an upbeat Sharif said he wasn't thinking about a coalition government but looking forward to his party winning a majority in parliament.

With his archrival Khan side-lined and in prison, Sharif seems on a sure path to the premiership, backed by his younger brother, former Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif. The younger Sharif, who is likely to have a role in the next Cabinet, told Geo news channel on Wednesday that his brother would become prime minister if their party gets a majority of the vote.

The only other strong contender is Pakistan People's Party. It has a power base in the south and is led by a rising star in national politics — Bilawal Bhutto-Zardari, the son of assassinated former Prime Minister Benazir Bhutto. He issued a statement, demanding restoration of the mobile phone service.

The Sharifs and Bhutto-Zardari are traditional rivals but have joined forces against Khan in the past, and Bhutto-Zardari served as foreign minister until last August, during Shehbaz Sharif's term as premier.

President Arif Alvi, who has a mostly ceremonial role in Pakistan, cast his ballot in the southern port city of Karachi. He urged people to vote, saying it's their duty as citizens.

'SWEDEN HAS THWARTED IRANIAN ATTACK PLOTS'

AP
Stockholm, Feb. 8

A senior member of the Swedish security police said Thursday that Iran has planned attacks on the country, days after local media reported that two Iranians were deported for a plot to kill three Swedish Jews several years ago.

Earlier this week, Swedish broadcast SR reported that two Iranians had been suspected of planning to kill members of the Swedish Jewish community. They were arrested in 2021 and were expelled from Sweden in 2022 without charges, according to Swedish radio.

Daniel Stenling, counterespionage head at Sweden's domestic security agency, told SR on Thursday that Iran "has been preparing and conducted activities aimed at carrying out a so-called physical attack against someone or something in Sweden."

He added, "we have worked on a number of such cases where we have, as we gauge it, thwarted such preparations." He declined to give specifics.

The two deported Iranians sought asylum in the Scandinavian country in 2015, claiming to be Afghans, and eventually got shelter in Sweden, according to SR. The report identified them as Mahdi Ramezani and Fereshteh Sanaeifarid, and said they have links to Iran's Revolutionary Guard.

A Swedish prosecutor earlier confirmed to The Associated Press that the two, a man and woman, were suspected of planning to carry out an attack "deemed to be terror" and that they have been expelled from Sweden. Prosecutor Hans Ihrman did not say when.

Ihrman told the AP that the prosecution "failed to get the necessary evidence that had been a prerequisite to be able to bring charges." He also declined to give further details.

Haiti's premier urges calm as protests seek his ouster



PHOTO: AP

A protester run from tear gas fired by riot police officers during a demonstration demanding the resignation of Prime Minister Ariel Henry in Port-au-Prince, Haiti, Wednesday, Feb. 7, 2024.

AP
Port-Au-Prince, Haiti, Feb. 8

Haitian Prime Minister Ariel Henry urged calm in a public address early Thursday following three days of violent protests that have paralyzed the country demanding his resignation.

The brief speech did little to appease thousands of people angry and frustrated over unrelenting gang violence, deepening poverty and no general elections in sight.

"I think the time has arrived for all to put our heads together to save Haiti, to do things another way in our country," Henry said without offering specifics.

He urged Haitians not to look at the government or at Haiti's National Police as their adversaries. Those who choose violence, destruction and killing people to take power are "not working in the interests of the Haitian people," he said.

His comments come as thousands of Haitians gathered daily this week in cities and towns across the country to demand that Henry step down, saying they will keep protesting until he leaves.

Haiti's legislature is currently empty, after the terms of its last 10 senators expired in January 2023. The country failed to hold planned elections in 2019 and 2023, and Henry assumed power with the support of the international community following the July 2021 assassination of President Jovenel Moïse.

On Wednesday, police killed five armed environmental protection agents in the capital of Port-au-Prince in a shooting some worry could worsen Haiti's crisis.

Lionel Lazarre, head of a police union known as Synapoha, told The Associated Press that the shooting between police and agents with Haiti's Security Brigade for Protected Areas occurred in the Laboule community. He claimed that the environmental agents opened fire after police asked them to drop their weapons, prompting officers to shoot.

The environmental division has recently come under scrutiny after its agents in northern Haiti clashed with police.

Henry said Haitians need peace, security, work and the ability to move freely around the country.

"Haitian people need for their children to go to school without fear, because that's what's going to guarantee them a future," he said.

Henry once again pledged to hold general elections as soon as Haiti's insecurity issues are resolved, saying he would continue to reach out and work with all those who want the country to move forward, "to take decisions together that are going to help us emerge from the crisis."

He also congratulated police for their efforts in fighting gangs and promised he would keep pushing for the U.N.-backed deployment of a Kenyan police force that is currently blocked by a court order.

"I want to reassure everyone the government will do whatever it can for the mission to come as fast as possible," he said.

Henry also extended his sympathies to all those who have died in the violent protests this week.

Volcano erupts in Iceland again

AP
Grindavik, Iceland, Feb. 8

A volcano in southwestern Iceland erupted for the third time since December on Thursday, sending jets of lava into the sky and triggering the evacuation of the Blue Lagoon spa, one of the island nation's biggest tourist attractions.

The eruption began at about 0600 GMT (1 a.m. EST) along a three-kilometre (nearly two-mile) fissure northeast of Mount Sundhnukur, the Icelandic Meteorological Office said. The event is taking place about four kilometres (2½ miles) northeast of Grindavik, a coastal town of 3,800 people that was evacuated before a previous eruption on Dec. 18.

The Icelandic Meteorological Office said that lava was flowing to the west and there was no immediate threat to Grindavik. or to a major power plant in the area. Civil defense officials said that no one was believed to be in the town at the time of the eruption, Icelandic national broadcaster RUV reported.

"They weren't meant to be, and we don't know about any," Víðir Reynisson, the head of Iceland's Civil Defense, told Icelandic national broadcaster RUV.

The nearby Blue Lagoon thermal spa was closed when the eruption began and all the guests were safely evacuated, RUV said.

The Icelandic Met Office said earlier this week warned of a possible eruption after monitoring a buildup of subsurface magma for the past three weeks. The amount of magma or semi-molten rock that had accumulated was similar to the amount released during an eruption in January.

Hundreds of small earthquakes had been measured in the area since last Friday, capped by a burst of intense seismic activity about a half-hour before the latest eruption began.

Dramatic video from Iceland's coast guard shows fountains of lava soaring more than 50 meters (165 feet) into the darkened skies. A plume of vapour is rising about three kilometres (1½ miles) above the volcano.



PHOTO: AP

A view of the volcano erupting, north of Grindavík, Iceland, Thursday, Feb. 8, 2024.

This is the third eruption since December of a volcanic system on the Reykjanes Peninsula, which is home to Keflavik, Iceland's main airport. There was no disruption reported to the airport on Thursday.

Iceland, which sits above a volcanic hot spot in the North Atlantic, averages an eruption every four to five years. The most disruptive in recent times was the 2010 eruption of the Eyjafjallajokull volcano, which spewed huge clouds of ash into the atmosphere and led to widespread airspace closures over Europe.

Grindavik, about 50 kilometres (30 miles) southwest of Iceland's capital, Reykjavik, was evacuated in November when the Svartsengi volcanic system awakened after almost 800 years with a series of earthquakes that opened large cracks in the earth between the town and Sylingarfell, a small mountain to the north.

The volcano eventually erupted on Dec. 18, sending lava flowing away from Grindavik. A second eruption that began on Jan. 14 sent lava towards the town. Defensive walls that had been bolstered since the first eruption stopped some of the flow, but several buildings were consumed by the semi-molten flow.

PRISM

Hose used to rescue horse stuck in pond

Florida: Fire-fighters in Florida used a length of hose to rescue a horse that walked out into a pond and became stuck.

Marion County Fire Rescue said in a Facebook post that crews from Weirsdale Station #27 responded to a 911 call about a horse stuck in a pond.

The fire-fighters arrived to find the "cold and weak" horse was unable to move from its position in about 4 feet of water.

"Fire-fighters were able to secure a boat and make their way out to the horse," the post said. "Utilizing their ingenuity and a bit of fire hose, crews were able free the horse."

Photos from the rescue show fire-fighters tying the hose around the horse's body so it could be pulled free from the muck.

"The horse was quickly brought to land and cared for by concerned citizens until the owner could be located," fire-fighters wrote.

Overturned truck covers highway

Nevada: Travellers on a Nevada highway hit an unusual traffic hiccup when an overturned truck covered the roadway in cans and bottles of Dr. Pepper and 7Up.

Nevada State Police said the truck overturned on Interstate 80, between Mogul and Garson in the Reno area.

The truck ended up on its side, spilling crates loaded with cans and bottles of Dr. Pepper and 7Up into the roadway.

No injuries were reported from the truck crash or the ensuing soda spill.

NHP said traffic in both directions was reduced to one lane due to multiple minor crashes in the area.

(Agencies)

Climate change fuelling disappearance of Aral Sea

AP
Muynak, Uzbekistan, Feb. 8

Toxic dust storms, anti-government protests, the fall of the Soviet Union — for generations, none of it has deterred Nafisa Bayniyazova and her family from making a living growing melons, pumpkins and tomatoes on farms around the Aral Sea.

Bayniyazova, 50, has spent most of her life near Muynak, in northwestern Uzbekistan, tending the land. Farm life was sometimes difficult but generally reliable and productive. Even while political upheaval from the Soviet Union's collapse transformed the world around them, the family's farmland yielded crops, with water steadily flowing through canals coming from the Aral and surrounding rivers.

Now, Bayniyazova and other residents say they're facing a catastrophe they can't beat: climate change, which is accelerating the decades-long demise of the Aral, once the lifeblood for the thousands living around it.

The Aral has nearly disappeared. Decades ago, deep blue and filled with fish, it was one of the world's largest inland bodies of water. It's shrunk to less than a quarter of its former size.

Much of its early demise is due to human engineering and agricultural projects gone awry, now paired with climate change. Summers are hotter and longer; winters, shorter and bitterly cold. Water is harder to find, experts and residents like Bayniyazova say, with salinity too high for plants to properly grow.

For decades, the Aral — fed by rivers relying heavily on glacial melt, and intersecting the landlocked countries of Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan — held meters-long fish, caught and shipped across the Soviet Union.

The region prospered, and thousands of migrants from across Asia and Europe moved to the Aral's shores, for jobs popping up everywhere from canning factories to luxury vacation resorts.

Today, the few remaining towns sit quiet along the former seabed of the Aral



FILE PHOTO: AP

Nafisa Bayniyazova poses for a photo with her dog Alabai, on her farm near Muynak, Uzbekistan, Wednesday, June 28, 2023.

— technically classified as a lake, due to its lack of a direct outlet to the ocean, though residents and officials call it a sea. Dust storms whip through, and rusted ships sit in the desert.

In the 1920s, the Soviet government began to drain the sea for irrigation of cotton and other cash crops. By the 1960s, it shrunk by half; those crops thrived. By 1987, the Aral's level was so low it split into two bodies of water: the northern and southern seas, in Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan, respectively.

The United Nations Development Program calls the destruction of the Aral Sea "the most staggering disaster of the 20th century." It points to the Aral's demise as the cause of land degradation and desertification, drinking water shortages, malnutrition, and deteriorating health conditions.

National governments, international aid organizations and local groups have tried — with varying degrees of effort and success —to save the sea. Efforts range from planting bushes for slowing the encroaching dunes to building multimillion-dollar dams.

TODAY IN HISTORY

474 – Zeno is crowned as co-emperor of the Byzantine Empire.
1003 – Boleslaus III is restored to authority with armed support from Bolesław I the Brave of Poland.
1775 – American Revolutionary War: The British Parliament declares Massachusetts in rebellion.
1778 – Rhode Island becomes the fourth US state to ratify the Articles of Confederation.
1788 – The Habsburg Empire joins the Russo-Turkish War in the Russian camp.
1849 – The new Roman Republic is declared.
1893 – Verdi's last opera, Falstaff premieres at La Scala, Milan.
1895 – William G. Morgan creates a game called Mintonette, which soon comes to be referred to as volleyball.
1900 – The Davis Cup competition is established.



PHOTO: RSS

President Ramchandra Paudel presenting National Journalism Award to senior journalist Kishor Nepal at a function organised by Minkumari Rana Foundation at Sheetal Niwas, Kathmandu on Thursday.

'Good governance main basis for development'

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 8

President Ramchandra Paudel has said that corruption-free society and good-governance is a main basis for development.

Addressing a prize distribution programme organised by Minkumari Rana Foundation at the Office of the President on Thursday, the President said happiness in the face of poor, marginalised and backward people and communities could be ensured from the lasting peace, development and good-governance.

The President viewed that services to the people and society should be our main target though politics was more dominant in the past.

"Prizing and honouring the personalities for their contributions to the different sectors in the society could encourage the future generation to do good deeds," the President shared.

On the occasion, President Paudel believed that the Foundation would work by implementing special programmes for the welfare and promotion of marginalized class and sectors in coming days.

Likewise, President Paudel recalled the contributions made by late Minkumari and her family for Nepal's democratic movement.

He also expressed satisfaction for the proactive roles of the Foundation in the areas of human rights, press freedom and democracy, education, health and sports.

During the event, democratic leader Lekhnath Neupane was honoured with 'Minkumari Prajatantra Senani Samman', senior journalist Kishore Nepal with 'National Journalism Prize' and Prakash Thapamagar with 'National Sports Prize'.

President Paudel gave away the prizes to the recipients.

MINISTER BASNET ASSURES FREE HEALTHCARE SERVICES

RSS
Lalitpur, Feb. 8

Minister for Health and Population Mohan Bahadur Basnet has insisted on translating free provisions for health and education enshrined by the Constitution into action.

All citizens should have access to healthcare facilities guaranteed by the Constitution, he said, adding that the government has taken steps to enforce the constitutional provisions for free healthcare facilities.

In his address to an inaugural session of the Adolescents' Mental Health Unit at the Mental Health Hospital, Lagankhel on Thursday, the Minister said 10 out of every 100 adolescents are found to have mental issues.

He commended the hospital for establishing a dedicated unit to provide mental health services to adolescents. The Minister spoke of the need for collective efforts among the State, social organisations and citizens to mitigate mental health challenges by enhancing access to mental health services.

Lalitpur constituency 2 lawmaker Prem Bahadur Maharjan, Norwegian ambassador to Nepal, Torun Dramdal, and CWIN Nepal executive director Sumnina Tualadhar were among those putting their views in the programme.

The Norwegian ambassador pledged to cooperate with the Nepal government in latter's endeavours to address mental health problems.

Blinken ends Mideast mission after Israel snubs truce plan

AP
Tel Aviv, Feb. 8

U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken left the Middle East on Thursday with public divisions between the United States and Israel at perhaps their worst level since Israel's war against Hamas in Gaza began in October.

Wrapping up a four-nation Mideast trip — his fifth to the region since the conflict erupted — Blinken was returning to Washington after getting a virtual slap in the face from Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who said the war would continue until Israel is completely victorious and appeared to reject outright a response from Hamas to a proposed cease-fire plan.

Relations between Israel and its main international ally, the United States, have been tense for months, but Netanyahu's public dismissal of a plan the U.S. says has merit, at least as a starting point for further negotiation, highlighted the divide.

Yet Blinken and other U.S. officials said they remained optimistic that progress could be made on their main goals of improving humanitarian conditions for Palestinians civilians, securing the release of hostages held by Hamas, preparing for a post-conflict Gaza and preventing the war from spreading.

Officials said Blinken's optimism was based on his first four post-Oct. 7 trips to the Middle East. None of those visits resulted in immediate visible successes, but they brought limited but significant improvements in the delivery of humanitarian aid and a week-long cease-fire in November in which scores of hostages were released.

"Clearly there are things that Hamas sent back that are absolute non-starters," Blinken said of the response the militant group delivered Tuesday to a cease-fire and hostage release proposal that was endorsed last month by Egypt, Qatar, the U.S. and Israel itself.

"But, at the same time, we see space to continue to pursue an agreement," Blinken said late Wednesday. "And these things are always negotiations. It's not flipping a light switch. It's not 'yes' or 'no.' There's invariably back and forth."

Shortly before Blinken spoke, though, Netanyahu took direct aim at the Hamas response, calling it "delusional" and vowing that Israel would fight on to achieve "absolute victory" over the militant group, no matter what.

Compounding Blinken's dilemma, Netanyahu also appeared to dismiss concerns from the U.S. and others about expanding Israel's military operations in southern Gaza, particularly in Rafah, the area on the Egyptian border to which over a million Palestinians have fled.

"On all of my previous visits here and pretty much every day in between, we have pressed Israel in concrete ways to strengthen civilian protection, to get more assistance to those who need it. And over the past four months, Israel has taken important steps to do just that," he said. "And yet … the daily toll that its military operations continue to take on innocent civilians remains too high."

Netanyahu also called for the dismantlement of UNRWA, the UN agency for Palestinian refugees, which is the main distributor of international assistance to Gaza, because of its alleged hostility toward Israel and allegations that a dozen of its employees took part in the Oct. 7 Hamas attack that ignited the war.

The U.S. and other donor nations have suspended new assistance to UNRWA pending completion of a U.N. investigation into the allegations, but Blinken has nonetheless said the agency's role is critical to getting desperately needed humanitarian supplies into Gaza.

Blinken appealed to Netanyahu and other Israelis still reeling from the Hamas attack not to allow vengeance to dictate their continued response.

"Israelis were dehumanized in the most horrific way on October 7," he said. "And the hostages have been dehumanized every day since. But that cannot be a license to dehumanize others."

Blinken came to Israel just hours after the receipt of the Hamas counter-proposal to the framework cease-fire agreement put forward late last month. That proposal includes a three-phase plan to de-escalate the conflict.

In Qatar on Tuesday, both Qatar's prime minister and Blinken said the proposal had promise as a starting point for further negotiation.

And Blinken talked up Saudi Arabia's interest in normalizing relations with Israel, provided the Gaza war ends and the Palestinians are given a clear, credible and time-bound pathway to an independent state.

Opposition parties rise against govt in Bagmati

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Hetauda, Feb. 8

The Bagmati Province government's failure to implement the past agreements with the opposition parties, notably the CPN-UML representing the Bagmati Province Assembly, has prompted the opposition to stand against the government.

The deadlock emerged when the provincial government ignored the agreements inked in June last year during the budget presentation for the current fiscal year 2023/24, coupled with a delayed commencement of the provincial assembly session. In response, opposition parties, led by the CPN-UML, are forming the burricade.

During the budget presentation, the CPN-UML and other parties obstructed the Provincial Assembly meeting, citing concerns about the budget's imbalance, discrimination and insufficient provisions for the province's development. The obstruction ceased after the CPN (Maoist Centre)-led coalition government committed to addressing the opposition's concerns within the budget, leading to the reconvening of the Provincial Assembly and approval of the budget.

Subsequently, the CPN-UML and other opposition parties are gearing up to formally request the provincial chief to convene the Provincial Assembly session. This decision stems from the government's failure to fulfil commitments made during a previous all-party meeting, resulting in a delay in summoning the Provincial Assembly session.

The UML Bagmati Province Parliamentary Party held a press conference,

During the budget presentation, the CPN-UML and other parties obstructed the Provincial Assembly meeting, citing concerns about the budget's imbalance, discrimination and insufficient provisions for the province's development.

affirming their readiness to legally challenge the government's actions. Jagannath Thapaliya, leader of the CPN-UML Bagmati Province Parliamentary Party, expressed dissatisfaction over the government's lack of commitment and reluctance to convene the Provincial Assembly meeting, to represent the people's voice. He emphasised the party's intent to caution the government according to parliamentary values.

Thapaliya accused the government of dishonesty for disregarding past agreements and disclosed plans for the opposition to formally request the provincial chief to convene the session in writing if the government fails to act by mid-February.

Referring to the Constitution of Nepal, Thapaliya highlighted that if one-fourth of provincial assembly members submit a written request to the chief of the province, the session's date and time must be scheduled. He reiterated that due to the government's failure to convene the session, discussions within the opposition parties about submitting a written request have progressed.

Investment...

Mukunda Niraula, Secretary of the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies, and Coordinator of the Technical Committee, made a presentation regarding the preparation of the projects to be presented at the NIS 2024. The technical committee has prepared a preliminary list of projects by classifying them in various stages of project study and proceeded with further homework, informed the Investment Board of Nepal (IBN).

Sushil Bhatta, Coordinator of the Investment Conference Secretariat and CEO IBN, made a detailed presentation about the overall preparations for the NIS.

Ministers of various ministries, Vice-Chairman of National Planning Commission, Dr. Min Bahadur Shrestha, Chief Secretary Dr. Baikuntha Aryal, Governor of the Nepal Rastra Bank, Maha Prasad Adhikari, secretaries of various ministries, and private sector representatives were present at the meeting.

Govt annuls...

Similarly, the Cabinet meeting has given agreement in principle to draft a bill to make arrangements for the Electricity Governance Commission.

Minister Sharma said that the government endorsed the Family Identification and Distribution of Identity Cards (First Amendment) Guidelines, 2080.

Likewise, the Cabinet appointed Dr. Parshuram Mishra of Mahottari district as chairman of Ramraja Prasad Singh Institute of Health Sciences.

Govt firm to punish the...

The Home Minister reminded that the judicial and administrative process was going on at various stages to give justice to the victims of loan-sharking. At the same time, he said that the government has taken steps to punish those who cheated in the name of cooperatives and give justice to the victims.

Minister Shrestha, who is also the patron of the Maoist's Base Shelter (Aadharsheela) established in Gauridanda, Bardibas, held the opinion that the practice of an organisation like Aadharsheela is helpful and motivating when the process of ideological deviation and cultural alienation is intense in the communist movement of Nepal.

Earlier, speaking at a security briefing meeting held with the Province Chiefs of security bodies, including CDOs of the Madhes Province, DPM Shrestha directed the administrative and security agencies to coordinate and work for the maintenance of security in the Province.

DPM Shrestha ordered the security chiefs and Chief District Officers to maintain religious tolerance and curb corruption through administrative measures.

In the programme, CDOs of Mahottari and Dhanusha, province chiefs of the Armed Police Force Nepal and Nepal Police and province chief of the National Investigation Department and District Security Chiefs reported Home Minister Shrestha about the overall security situation of the province, said Home Minister's press coordinator Kamal Giri.

DPM Shrestha instructed security officials to take action against drug peddlers, conduct awareness programmes to deter youths from taking drugs, create correctional centres and work in coordination with the provincial and local governments to control drug trafficking.

DPM Shrestha said that the government was working on adding border outposts to control revenue leakage, control illegal transactions and prevent cross-border crime.

He also instructed security bodies to take necessary actions to control possible loan sharking.

Bridge found being constructed...

Mandal asserted that the construction work on the bridge would commence within a week. He also said that the bridge was built at the location specified by the project implementing agency and the local authorities at that time.

One local, Om Prakash Mehata, alleged that the bridge was constructed to connect a secondary road leaving the main road. He claimed that the chairman of another ward misused the letter pad of the concerned ward to recommend building the bridge four kilometres north of its original location.

The Tangra River bridge construction location recommended in Barju Ward No. 5 letterhead aligns with the map of Barju Rural Municipality Ward No. 5 and 2. However, recent correspondence said that the former Amaduwa VDC Ward No. 5 and 8 are now part of Barju Rural Municipality Ward No. 4, including the Tengra area.

Bangladesh Foreign Minister hails ties with India during official visit

ANI/RSS
New Delhi, Feb. 8

Hailing the ties with India, Bangladesh Foreign Minister Hasan Mahmud, currently on an official visit to India, said that India is an immediate neighbour, and the relationship is bonded by blood.

While speaking to ANI, the foreign minister emphasized that India is not only a neighbour but also played a vital role in Bangladesh's independence war.

On Bangladesh PM Sheikh Hasina visiting Indi's future visit, Mahmud said, "You are having elections... In the future, definitely, PM Shiekh Hasina will visit India... India is our immediate neighbour.

We have a wide range of issues. India is not only our neighbour, but it also played a very vital role in our independence war. Indian people and the army shed their blood. Our relationship is bonded by blood. The invitation came from India first. That's why I chose India for my first foreign visit..."

Regarding his meetings with his Indian counterpart, S Jaishankar, the Bangladesh Foreign Minister mentioned that they discussed all issues, including cross-border issues, Rohingya, as well as connectivity.

"We had a very good discussion. We discussed all the issues including cross-border issues, Rohingya issues, security issues, powersharing and



connectivity issues. We discussed all of these issues..." he told ANI.

Meanwhile, when asked about the Pakistan General Elections, scheduled for Thursday, he said that "it is their internal issue."

Earlier, Bangladesh Foreign Minister Hasan Mahmud said that his visit to India will contribute to strengthening the ties between the two 'brotherly' countries, which have excellent ties.

Mahmud, who is on a visit to India from February 7-9, arrived in the national capital in the early hours of Wednesday.

Speaking to ANI, Mahmud said, "We are two brotherly countries. We have excellent ties between the two countries. Any visit of a Bangladesh minister or an Indian minister to Bangladesh definitely strengthens our ties."

The Bangladesh Foreign Minister also thanked EAM Jaishankar and the Indian government for inviting him on Wednesday.

"We value the visit because I have come here on the invitation of the Foreign Minister of India. We are thankful to the Indian Government and especially to the Foreign Minister for inviting me here. Definitely, this visit will contribute to the relationship," he added.

Earlier in the day, FM Mahmud met with National Security Advisor Ajit Doval. The two leaders held discussions on exploring avenues for enhanced regional cooperation to ensure security and foster greater stability not only within the region but also beyond.

Notably, this is Mahmud's first foreign visit after being sworn into the new Bangladesh government following Sheikh Hasina's historic victory, securing a consecutive fourth term as Prime Minister.

Hasan Mahmud, who hails from Chittagong in the southeast of Bangladesh, served as Deputy Foreign Minister during Sheikh Hasina's second term during 2009-2014.

Hasina's party, the Awami League, secured 223 seats to form the government in the elections held on January 7. The Awami League government named its 36-member cabinet after President Mohammad Shahabuddin invited them to form the government.

Masinya: Story of injustice meted out against Tamang



BY RENUKA DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 8

The fundamental principle of law is to ensure equal treatment and protection of basic rights for all citizens, regardless of the community they belong to or the status they uphold.

However, instances are there to show how laws in the past were biased, favouring certain castes over others.

In 1854, Jung Bahadur Rana, the first Rana Prime Minister implemented the 'Muluki Ain'.

This law divided individuals into specific groups, including 'Tagadhari,' defined as the upper caste wearing the sacred thread, 'Matwali,' who consumed alcohol, and 'Achhut,' referred to so-called untouchables.

Further, the same law divided 'Matwali' into two groups, including 'Masinya Matwali,' meaning a race that could be killed or enslaved for free, and 'Namasinya Matwali,' meaning non-enslavable but alcohol consumers.

Certain indigenous communities like Tharu, Tamang, and Bhote were labelled 'Masinya Matwali', who could be enslaved by the ruling elites.

Meanwhile, others like Magar, Sunuwar, Gurung, Rai, and Limbu were placed in the 'Namasinya Matwali' category. These classifications not only offended the sentiments of those categorised but also posed a challenge to the principles of humanity and societal harmony.

Poets Raju Syangtang, Laxmi Rumba, and Rabat have been articulating the injustices, suffering, and humiliation endured by their community through their poetry for quite some time.

However, this time they narrated their community's story on stage with the play 'Masinya'.

The play titled 'Masinya,' currently being staged at Mandala Theatre, delves into the lives, cultures, languages, and the oppression faced by Tamang communities due to power dynamics.

The title itself reflects the oppressive categorisation introduced by Jung Bahadur Rana. However, the drama is set against the background of the Maoist insurgency period.

The play depicts the discrimination faced by indigenous people, particularly the Tamang community, for their traditional consumption of beef.

The protagonist, Chyangba, is unjustly arrested and tortured by the police for consuming beef, a practice deeply rooted in his community's customs for a long time.

The play opens with a ritualistic scene as shamans attempt to heal a mentally ill young woman by chanting mantras and playing 'dyangro' (musical instruments used while performing shamanism).

The head Shaman posed questions to an ill girl with chanting mantras, and then the girl started trembling and said she was the spirit of an oppressed Tamang girl.

Then the scene would transport the audience back in time to a Tamang village, the audience witnesses Chyangba meticulously crafting a 'Chorten', a symbolic homage to his ancestors.

He seeks to build a 'Chorten' in memory of his deceased parents.

However, his plans were thwarted when the local government constructed a road where Chyangba had built the 'Chorten', even though the road could have been constructed in another direction.

This incident highlights the disrespect of their culture and faith in the name of modernisation by authority, even in democratic practices.

The play not only revolves around sorrow and pain, it beautifully portrays the liveliness, culture, love story, and natural beauty of Tamang life.

The narrative unfolds the rich culture and emotions, weaving together moments of joy, laughters and tears simultaneously.

The captivating rhythms of Tamang songs, accompanied by the lively tunes of 'Damphu' and 'Tugna', deeply engage the audience in the performance.

Amidst the serious themes, humorous conversations and mischievous actions between characters in the play in various scenes offer comic relief to the audience.

The drama's captivating performance, melodious music and the use of light made it an enjoyable experience, but some scenes, particularly the opening scene, felt overly prolonged.

At the end, when Chyangba holds a sword, it shows that the Tamang community wants fair treatment and it tries to convey a strong message that they are ready to fight for their rights if they are not treated equally.

Reflecting on history, the injustices meted out against them in the name of power politics evoke deep emotions and give unbearable pains not only to the Tamang community but also upon all who cherish the morals of humanity.

On the other hand, the play portrays how the Tamang community treats females at home with significant power, often surpassing that of males.

In the so-called upper castes, females are often treated as inferior to males, with male chauvinism and patriarchal norms imposed on them in the name of culture and religion.

However, in the Tamang community, females are treated with honour and respect, which should be learned by all people even in today's age.

Another highlight of the play is in the Tamang community, where conversations between parents and children are very open, allowing them to share their feelings like friends.

As modern education continuously emphasises the importance of parents understanding children's feelings and psychology, becoming a friend, a value the many Matwali communities have gracefully upheld for a long time.

Directed and conceptualised by Buddhi Tamang and Sonam Lama, the play will be staged till February 11.

Durgalal Shrestha, poet Raj Bhai Jakami honoured



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 8

Nepa: Pasa Pucha: America conferred honorary patronage to Durgalal Shrestha, the Nepal Bhasha (Newari language) poet, and folk poet Raj Bhai Jakami in Kathmandu.

Sunita Dangol, Deputy Mayor of Kathmandu Metropolitan City, emphasised the significance of honouring two generations simultaneously, citing its potential to inspire the youth to Newari language, art and culture.

Stressing the importance of language as an element of identity, Dangol urged parents to converse with their children in their native tongue.

President Manohar Shrestha of Nepa: Pasa Pucha :America highlighted the purpose behind honouring them.

The organisation was established in America approximately 32 years ago.

Unfortunately, esteemed poet Shrestha couldn't attend the event due to health reasons, but his message was conveyed through a recording.

Expressing his delight, honoured poet Jakami shared that he has been dedicated to literary pursuits for 14 years under the mentorship of Shrestha and honouring together with him was a big coincidence.

Freelance journalists win $100,000

AP
New York, Feb. 8



Two freelance journalists with projects focused on Black nationalism and the aftermath of the Uvalde school shooting have won the American Mosaic Journalism Prize, which honors work about underrepresented groups in the United States.

The journalists, Dara T. Mathis and Tamir Kalifa, were each awarded $100,000 from the Heising-Simons Foundation. That's believed to be the largest prize in dollar value given to journalists in the United States. The Maryland-based Mathis was honored for her article in The Atlantic, "A Blueprint for Black Liberation," where she wrote about growing up in a radical Black commune and the broader history of such movements. She's working on expanding that piece into a memoir.

"As a Black writer, I am keenly aware of how the stories of marginalized people are excluded from the archive," Mathis said. "My work as a journalist seeks to connect silenced histories to our present day."

Photojournalist Tamir Kalifa won for his work on the aftermath of the 2022 mass shooting at the Robb elementary school in Uvalde, Texas. The Austin-based Kalifa is currently in Israel covering the Israel-Hamas war. Kalifa said he's spent the last few years of his career trying to document the resilience of people who are enduring tragedy.

DISNEY TO INVEST $1.5 BILLION IN 'FORTNITE' MAKER EPIC GAMES

AP
Calif, Feb. 8

The Walt Disney Co. said Wednesday it is paying $1.5 billion for a stake in "Fortnite" maker Epic Games, working with the game developer to create a "games and entertainment universe" that will feature games, shows and characters from Disney, Pixar, Marvel, Star Wars, Avatar and more.

"This marks Disney's biggest entry ever into the world of games and offers significant opportunities for growth and expansion," Disney CEO Bob Iger said in a statement. Disney said the two companies have already collaborated on "Fortnite" content, including the Marvel "Nexus War with Galactus," which drew more than 15.3 million concurrent players.

Christian Bale breaks ground on foster homes he's fought for 16 years

AP
Calif, Feb. 8

Christian Bale broke ground Wednesday on a project he's been pursuing for 16 years -- the building of a dozen homes and a community center in Los Angeles County intended to keep siblings in foster care together.

The Oscar winner stood with a grin and a shovel full of dirt alongside local politicians and donors in the decidedly non-Hollywood city of Palmdale, 60 miles (80 kilometers) north and across the San Gabriel Mountains from Los Angeles.

But Bale, who was Batman in director Christopher Nolan 's "Dark Knight" trilogy, wasn't just playing Bruce Wayne and lending his name and money to a charitable cause.

The project was his brainchild and one he's long lent his labor to, getting his hands dirty and on Wednesday standing in actual mud after a historic storm on a hard-won site he'd visited many times before.

"I would have done it all if it was just me by myself here," Bale told The Associated Press in an interview on the large vacant lot between a public park and a bowling alley.

The British-born Bale has lived in California since the early 1990s and sought to build the community after hearing about the huge number of foster children in LA County, and learning how many brothers and sisters had to be separated in the system.



That was around 2008, the time of "The Dark Knight," when his now college-age daughter was 3 years old.

"I didn't think it was going to take that long," he said. "I had a very naive idea about kind of getting a piece of land and then, bringing kids in and the brothers and sisters living together and sort of singing songs like the Von Trapp family in 'The Sound of Music'. "

But he then learned "it's way more complex. These are people's lives. And we need to be able to have them land on their feet when they age out. There's so much involved in this."

Bale visited Chicago, spent several days in children and family services meetings. From there, he recruited Tim McCormick, who had set up a similar program, to head the organization that became known as Together California, a group Bale would co-found with UCLA doctor Eric Esrailian, a producer on one of his films.

"He said we've got to do this in California," McCormick said. "To his credit, through all sorts of challenges, COVID and everything else, he never gave up."

The men eventually found a sympathetic leader in LA County Supervisor Kathryn Barger, and in Palmdale, a semi-rural city of about 165,000 people, found a city with both a need and a willingness to take part.

The 12 homes, anchored by the community center, are set to be finished in April of 2025.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: You're capable of recognizing what your friends mean to you today. When the nurturing Moon in your social sector aligns with tender Chiron in your sign, you can see how your community supports you.

TAURUS: Progress toward a major goal is possible for you. As the sensitive Moon in your ambitious 10th house hugs wounded Chiron in your 12th House of Secrets, you may successfully apply lessons you learned.

GEMINI: Achieving clarity regarding your personal beliefs is possible now. On the other hand, as the energetic New Moon highlights your philosophical 9th house,

CANCER: Opening up to a friend you trust could currently heal old wounds about authority figures. While the invigorating New Moon strikes in your 8th House of Intimacy.

LEO: A close relationship could provide the inspiration you crave at the moment. You've potentially been discouraged by disappointing experiences with optimistic plans in the past.

VIRGO: Changing the rules regarding routine tasks could be necessary at this time. With the potent New Moon in your responsible 6th house, you're probably acutely aware of all the chores that need to be done.

LIBRA: Adopting a relaxed attitude may presently bring comfort to a relationship that's been struggling. Although unresolved conflicts that affect your connection could continually weigh on you.

SCORPIO: You're likely in the mood to cocoon and clean up your surroundings at the moment. While the refreshing New Moon enlivens your domestic 4th house, indulging this impulse will probably make you feel a lot better.

SAGITTARIUS: Airing your feelings about a personal matter can improve your mood now. As the emotional Moon in your communication zone clashes with liberating Uranus in your productive 6th house.

CAPRICORN: Your efforts to achieve security could be visibly paying off. It's possible that taking note of the stability of your current resources will address any feelings of lack remaining from your upbringing.

AQUARIUS: Correcting unhelpful self-talk could improve your mindset today. As the perceptive Moon in your sign reins in ruminating Chiron in your communication sector.

PISCES: Embracing your inner strength can be rewarding today. Perhaps you've long been disappointed by the failure of others to support you in a particular way.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Nepal's gritting bowling seals win in first of three ODIs against Canada



PHOTO: BIKASH/TRN

Nepali cricket team's captain Rohit Paudel celebrates after taking a wicket against Canada in the first match of the Bilateral Series at TU Cricket Ground in Kirtipur on Thursday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 8

Captain Rohit Kumar Paudel was the man of the day for Nepal as his four-wicket haul helped the team win the first of the three ODI matches against Canada on Thursday.

Nepal, with two debutants, won the match by a bare margin of seven runs as Canada was bundled out for 217 runs by the end of the 48th over. With six bowlers claiming at least one wicket each, Nepal was able to defend a not-so-high target of 225 in front of a dazzling crowd at the TU International Cricket Ground. Electing to bat first, the opening pair of Kushal Bhurtel and Aasif Sheikh started in great form. They took the team to 48 runs before Aasif (8 off 24) departed as the first wicket in 9.1 overs.

Captain Paudel failed with the bat as he followed Aasif in the 15th over after facing 17 deliveries and adding eight runs. Bhurtel crossed the half-century mark but returned to the pavilion adding 62 off 58.

The middle order tried holding on as every batsman scored in double figures, but it was not enough. Bhim Sarki, Kushal Malla, Aarif Sheikh and Pawan Sarraf added 17, 20, 38 and 15 runs respectively.

Sompal Kami also added 27 runs in 23 balls while debutant Surya Tamang, staying not out, contributed 10 off 32.

Uday Bhagwan was Canada's highest wicket-taker with three while captain Saad Bin Zafar and Ishwarjot Sohi bagged two each. Shahid Ahmadzai and Harsh Thaker also claimed one each.

Thaker, Pargat Singh and Nicholas Kirton were the biggest headache for Nepal while defending the target. While Pargat departed after a half-century in 19.4 overs leaving Canada at 114/3, Thaker and Kirton took the team to 174. Kushal Malla came to the breakthrough as he bowled out Thaker (32 off 43) in the 33rd over.

Canada was in the chase until Kirton was at the crease. However, after he was bowled out by Sarraf, who returned to the national team after a long break, in the 41st over, Nepal was back in the game. Kirton departed at 66 runs off 99 deliveries.

While opener Aaron Johnson added 20 off 15, none of the other Canadian batsmen scored in double digits. Paudel bowled out Sohi in the 48th over to win the match for Nepal.

Canada's captain and most experienced player Zafar was still at the crease making Nepali fans nervous as the target was low. However, he was one of the five wickets that fell in the final powerplay without adding enough runs on the board for the team.

Meanwhile, Paudel bowled two maiden overs and gave only 22 runs in his spell of 8.5 overs while he took four wickets. Lalit Rajbanshi bagged two wickets, and Kami, Sarraf and Malla took one each.

While debutant Tamang, who was the highest wicket-taker in the PM Men's Cup 2024, did not open his account in international cricket, another debutant Rijan Dhakal took his first. Dhakal bagged the wicket of opener Navneet Dhaliwal in his first over in international cricket.

Dhakal gave 34 runs in seven overs while Tamang gave away 32 runs in his spell of five overs. Captain Paudel started bowling more overs after he saw the team losing. He used his experience effectively to play a captain's inning and win the match for the team.

Meanwhile, while two players debuted for Nepal, five players – Sohi, Dhaliwal, Shreyas Movva, Ahmadzai and Bhagwan – debuted for Canada in the ODI format.

The second match of the bilateral series of 3 ODIs will be played on February 10 with the final match played on February 12. Nepal will be looking forward to clinching the series by winning the second ODI in front of a bigger crowd on Saturday.

Qatar sets up Asian Cup final with Jordan



AFP
Doha, Feb. 8

Goal-scorer Akram Afif said "the best is yet to come" after hosts and holders Qatar squeezed into an Asian Cup final against Jordan with a dramatic 3-2 win over Iran on Wednesday.

Almoez Ali struck in the 82nd minute in Doha to send Qatar into their second consecutive final, further exorcising the demons of their first-round exit at the 2022 World Cup.

Qatar lost all three of their World Cup games on home soil just over a year ago, the worst record of any host in the competition's history.

But that was all a distant memory as they celebrated in front of over 40,000 fans after a breathless semi-final at Al Thumama Stadium. "This victory was not easy," said Afif, who scored his fifth goal of the tournament to give Qatar a half-time lead.

"We are very proud of ourselves and our fans. They deserve tonight's win and hopefully the best is yet to come."

Iran had Shojae Khalilzadeh sent off in injury time before an ugly confrontation between both sets of players flared after the final whistle.

"The things we were hearing from the stands was not really nice and respectful, that's why there was a reaction afterwards," said Iran winger Alireza Jahanbakhsh. It came at the end of a frenetic encounter that saw both teams go on the attack from the first whistle.

Sardar Azmoun gave Iran the lead in the fourth minute before Qatar equalised soon after when Jassem Gaber's shot went in via a heavy deflection.

Afif then scored with a wonderful strike minutes before half-time, only for Iran to equalise through a Jahanbakhsh penalty early in the second period. Match-winner Ali scored an Asian Cup-record nine goals to lead Qatar to the 2019 title but he had managed only one heading into the semi-finals of this year's tournament.

His late strike was worth the wait for Qatar, who will now try to beat Jordan in Saturday's final for their second Asian title. "I think that we played a very big match," said Qatar coach Tintin Marquez, who took over from Carlos Queiroz only a month before the tournament. "The players did not spare any effort tonight. Now we have one final step left in order for us to defend our title."

Qatar's win ended Iran's bid for a first Asian Cup since 1976.

They had several chances to take the game into extra time, with Jahanbakhsh hitting the post in the final minute of added time. Coach Amir Ghalenoei apologised to the Iranian fans and called it "one of the worst days of my life".

"But this is football and if you don't take your chances then you will be punished," he added.

SNIPPETS

Chelsea wins at Aston Villa

London (AP): So much for Chelsea being in crisis. A 3-1 win at Aston Villa in an FA Cup fourth-round replay on Wednesday extended Chelsea's strong run of results in the domestic cup competitions this season, just as critics were getting on manager Mauricio Pochettino's back for the team's many dismal displays in the Premier League. Chelsea arrived at Villa Park having been routed 4-1 at Liverpool and then overrun in a 4-2 home loss to Wolverhampton, both in the league. Nottingham Forest also advanced in a replay — and was rewarded with a home match against Manchester United — after beating second-tier Bristol City 5-3 in a penalty shootout. The game finished 1-1 at the end of extra time.

PSG advances

Paris (AP): Kylian Mbappé scored his 30th goal of the season Wednesday as Paris Saint-Germain advanced to the French Cup quarterfinals with a 3-1 win over Brest that extended its unbeaten run to 15 matches. Amid persistent rumors he will leave PSG to join Real Madrid after his contract runs out at the end of June, Mbappé has been in tremendous form this season. Last weekend, the France captain scored his 20th league goal in just 19 matches. According to data by Opta, Mbappé has been involved in 50 goals in 28 French Cup games — 35 goals and 15 assists — scoring 11 goals in his last four matches in the competition.

Athletic beats Atletico

Madrid (AP): Athletic Bilbao ended Atletico Madrid's 28-match unbeaten streak at home with a 1-0 win in the first leg of the Copa del Rey semifinals on Wednesday. Álex Berenguer converted a first-half penalty kick to give Athletic the tight victory at the Metropolitano Stadium. Atletico hadn't lost at the Metropolitano since a 1-0 defeat against Barcelona in January last year in the Spanish league. Diego Simeone's team had only two draws since then, both against Getafe in the Spanish league. Berenguer scored the winner by converting a 25th-minute penalty after a hard sliding tackle by Atletico defender Reinildo on Athletic midfielder Beñat Prados. The second leg will be on Feb. 29 at Athletic's San Mames Stadium. Athletic beat Atletico 2-0 in a league match there in December.

Nigeria fixes AFCON final against hosts Ivory Coast

AFP
Abidjan, Feb. 8



Substitute forward Kelechi Iheanacho and goalkeeper Stanley Nwabali played key roles as Nigeria beat South Africa 4-2 on penalties on Wednesday in an Africa Cup of Nations semi-final thriller.

The three-time champions will face hosts Ivory Coast, who dominated the Democratic Republic of Congo but had to settle for a 1-0 win in Abidjan, in the final on Sunday. Nigeria triumphed after a 1-1 draw following extra time in Bouake in the latest of many dramatic matches at this biennial African football showpiece.

"Our team has a huge state of mind. The team fights together, There are 25 of us (in the squad and) it's difficult to beat us," said Nigeria coach Jose Peseiro.

"I am very happy, the players are happy, they deserve it, we deserve it, the Super Eagles deserve it, the Nigerian people deserve it." South Africa coach Hugo Broos said: "Football can be cruel. You play a bad match against Cape Verde, you win on penalties. You play a very good match against Nigeria and lose on penalties."

Iheanacho from English second-tier club Leicester City had been an unused substitute in the five group and knockout matches that took the Super Eagles to the semi-finals.

He was thrust into action by Portuguese Peseiro for the first time after 102 minutes against South Africa and calmly converted the decisive spot-kick.

Nwabali, who plays for South African top-flight club Chippa United, saved shootout kicks from Teboho Mokoena and Evidence Makgopa. Nwabali conceded once in a draw with the Equatoguineans, then kept four clean sheets before being beaten by a Mokoena penalty in the 90th minute of regular time.

Mudau miss

Nigeria had taken the lead 23 minutes earlier, also from a penalty, which captain William Troost-Ekong converted.

South Africa captain and goalkeeper Ronwen Williams, who saved four kicks in a quarter-final shootout win over Cape Verde, could not stop a single kick. Before Iheanacho netted, fellow substitutes Terem Moffi and Kenneth Omeruo and Troost-Ekong converted penalties and Ola Aina blazed over.

In an absorbing match watched by a 32,000 crowd, Nigeria thought they had taken a two-goal lead on 85 minutes when star forward Victor Osimhen scored. But play was called back to the other end and, after the Egyptian referee checked the pitchside VAR monitor, he awarded South Africa the penalty that Mokoena netted.

South Africa played the final seven minutes with 10 men after Grant Kekana was shown a straight red card for a last-defender foul on Moffi.

It will be the eighth final appearance by Nigeria, who were champions in 1980, 1994 and 2013, and the fourth by 1992 and 2015 title winners Ivory Coast.

Later, after the seesaw struggle for supremacy in Bouake, the Ivory Coast continued a remarkable comeback in the tournament by defeating DR Congo.

Sebastien Haller was the 65th-minute match-winner as his boot connected with a cross and the ball struck the ground, then rose over goalkeeper Lionel Mpasi and into the net.

After a humiliating 4-0 thrashing by Equatorial Guinea in the group stage, the Ivorians squeezed into the knockout phase as the last of the four third-placed teams who qualified.

But the embarrassment of a record home loss to the Equatoguineans was forgotten as Franck Kessie was denied by the woodwork and Haller missed a great chance before becoming the hero.

Paris Olympics medals to contain 'piece of Eiffel Tower'

AFP
Paris, Feb. 8



The medals awarded at this year's Paris Olympics and Paralympics will feature a hexagon-shaped piece of iron taken from the original Eiffel Tower in their centre, organisers said as they unveiled their design on Thursday.

All 5,084 gold, silver and bronze medals for the Paris Games will feature the six-edged metal medallion which will be set like a gemstone under a design by elite French jewellery house Chaumet.

"We wanted to offer to all medal-winners at the Paris Olympics and Paralympics a piece of the Eiffel Tower from 1889," said the head of the local organising committee, Tony Estanguet.

The medals were "a combination of the most precious metals from the medals -- gold, silver and bronze -- with the most precious metal in our country, from this treasure that is the Eiffel Tower." The design by Chaumet, whose creations have adorned aristocrats and the affluent since 1780, also features a circular arrangement of ridges intended to catch the light and evoke the sun's rays.

The iron hexagon -- a shape which echoes the contours of mainland France -- is held in place by six spurs on each corner which are intended to resemble the rivets used on the Eiffel Tower.

The metal was taken from a Paris warehouse used to stock offcuts by the operating company which maintains the 330-metre (1,083-foot) landmark, known affectionately as the "Old Lady" in France.

"We found out that over the years during the maintenance of the Eiffel Tower that they were obliged to remove some of the original structure," Thierry Reboul, the director of ceremonies, explained during an advance preview of the medals for AFP and other media.

Medal design is a key part of each Games' aesthetic, along with the logo, mascots and opening ceremony.

Since 2004, the back of all medals show the Greek goddess Nike flying into the historic Panathinaikos stadium in Athens, site of the original Olympic Games of antiquity.

Paris organisers squeezed a concession from the International Olympic Committee, enabling them to slightly alter the design to add an Eiffel Tower to the scene.

All the metal used in the Paris medals, which weigh around half a kilogramme, has been recycled.

The last Olympics in Tokyo saw Japanese organisers also incorporate recycled metal, with each medal moulded from alloys extracted from used consumer electronics such as mobile phones and laptops.

WEATHER

Friday

Sunrise at 6:46 am, Sunset at 5:50 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Friday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly regions of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province.

Expected Temp.: 19 - 21°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Thursday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	26.3	4.7	0.0
Dadeldhura	16.8	2.0	0.0
Dhangadi	21.8	7.0	0.0
Birendranagar	23.0	4.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	20.3	7.4	0.0
Jumla	16.6	-6.2	0.0
Ghorahi	21.0	6.5	0.0
Pokhara	20.4	9.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	20.0	5.8	0.0
Simara	20.4	5.5	0.0
Kathmandu	19.7	3.0	0.0
Okhaldhunga	14.1	3.3	0.0
Taplejung	14.4	2.4	0.0
Dhankuta	18.8	5.6	0.0
Biratnagar	21.3	8.0	0.0
Jomsom	13.0	-3.5	0.0*
Dharan	20.0	9.0	0.0*
Lumle	15.1	3.0	0.0*
Janakpur	23.4	8.2	0.0*
Jiri	15.6	-2.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 9, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.44	Rs. 133.04
Euro	1	Rs. 142.55	Rs. 143.19
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 166.89	Rs. 167.65
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 151.48	Rs. 152.17
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.01	Rs. 86.40
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.25	Rs. 98.69
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.34	Rs. 98.79
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.88	Rs. 8.92
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.40	Rs. 18.49
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.32	Rs. 35.48
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.32	Rs. 36.48
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.69	Rs. 3.71
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.06	Rs. 36.22
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.77	Rs. 27.89
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.95	Rs. 10.00
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.64	Rs. 12.69
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.12	Rs. 19.20
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.93	Rs. 17.01
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 429.93	Rs. 431.88
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.34	Rs. 352.93

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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Monkey Menace And Plight Of Farmers



Anukram Adhikary

> The devastation of a farmer's crops by wildlife, particularly in impoverished communities, is not just a loss of food but a threat to their livelihood.

While scrolling through Instagram, I found a post on the famous "Routine of Nepal Banda" page that captured Nepal's 'trending' rural crisis. On January 29, 2024, the Ward-19 office of Lamachaur, Pokhara, issued a plea, requesting the felling of trees to address the havoc caused by monkeys. The office sought permission for the removal of trees as a measure to combat the issues. The post, reflecting deep-seated agricultural distress, ignited a debate among netizens. Comments ranged from equating the plea to an overreaction akin to burning a house to rid it of a mouse, calling for more trees in the fight against climate change, and critiquing harming natural habitats under the guise of self-preservation.

Amidst this digital back-and-forth, Nepal's Community Forestry (CF) is a critical element in this narrative. Nepal's CF is a globally acclaimed model characterised by advanced tenure types. It grants Community Forest User Group (CFUG) members perpetual rights to access, use, and manage forest resources under an approved management plan. As of 2020, the Department of Forests and Soil Conservation shows an impressive network of 22,266 CFUGs managing 2.24 million hectares, accounting for 35 per cent of Nepal's total forest resources. These groups encompass about 2.91 million households, or roughly 33 per cent of the total population, actively participating in forest management. Its success in reviving forests and fostering resilience amidst political and natural crises is noteworthy and commendable. Yet, this green revival has inadvertently intensified human-wildlife conflicts, particularly crop raiding by monkeys, or "monkey terrorism," as referred to by the locals in many villages across the country.





But behind these online debates lies a grim reality I witnessed during my field visits to Pyuthan, Salyan, Kaski, and Kavre districts between April and July 2023. While collecting data for my doctoral research, I personally witnessed Nepali farmers grappling with a dilemma: monkeys and other wildlife were relentlessly raiding their crops. These raids aren't just an inconvenience; they threaten Nepal's agrarian fabric, pushing the country's food security to the brink. Farmers, once the pride of Nepal's identity, are now abandoning their lands, a decision that looms like a shadow over the nation's future.

This crisis extends beyond mere inconvenience; it represents a critical intersection of poverty and conservation challenges. The devastation of a farmer's crops by wildlife, particularly in impoverished communities, is not just a loss of food but a threat to their livelihood. Such incidents often incite significant outrage, potentially reducing conservation efforts for the entire species involved. These conflicts, if left unaddressed, risk escalating into a persecution of whole species, overshadowing the need for sustainable solutions. The key to mitigating these conflicts lies in a balanced approach that benefits wildlife and the affected human communities, ensuring coexistence.

A farmer from Salyan articulated this desperation, expressing a forbidden wish to harm the monkeys, a move that could lead to fines or jail time. His words echo the sentiment that the government prioritises wildlife over people's livelihoods. Despite not wanting to harm the animals, farmers like him feel abandoned, with local governments offering little to no solutions.

So, what can be done? The answer certainly isn't in cutting down the trees. This would be counterproductive and unravel the progress made in forest conservation. Instead, the focus should shift to sustainable solutions involving community forestry (CF) and its associated bodies like the Federation of Community Forestry Users Nepal (FECOFUN).

Effective mitigation strategies are essential in areas where human and wildlife habitats intersect. Techniques like physical barriers, innovative farming practices, and traditional methods such as using smoke or noise to repel animals are vital. However, these mitigation efforts must consider the wildlife's unique behaviours, the local communities' socio-ecological dynamics, and the need for sustainable long-term solutions. Monkeys, known for their intelligence and social structures, present unique challenges, as deterrents effective against other animals may not suffice. The growing monkey population in Nepal, exacerbated by a lack of natural predators and proximity to human settlements, calls for reevaluating current strategies. Studies from regions like Himachal Pradesh, India, suggest that trapping and population control may be necessary. Yet, such measures must be considered carefully, respecting local customs, ecological balance, and ethical standards.

The situation demands a 'Cognitive Fix' or an educational approach, moving beyond mere deterrents to addressing the root causes of these conflicts. Moreover, raising public awareness is crucial, especially among the urban populace. The disconnect between the realities of rural life and the urban perspective on environmental issues must be bridged. The urban audience needs to understand the complexity of human-wildlife conflicts and their impact on rural farmers' lives. Furthermore, the fix includes land preservation and the creation of buffer zones, essential steps in maintaining a healthy balance between human settlements and wildlife habitats. Drawing from experiences in Bolivia, Uganda, and Wisconsin (USA), a co-management strategy involving local stakeholders, such as CFUGs, is crucial. These partnerships can facilitate the development of context-specific strategies, respecting each region's cultural and ecological uniqueness. This approach not only aims to mitigate conflicts but also to enhance community involvement in conservation efforts.

Traditionally, human responses to wildlife conflict involved direct retaliation against animals, a practice now often illegal or socially frowned upon. This shift in attitude turns a straightforward competitive relationship into a complex socio-political conflict, requiring nuanced and informed solutions. Additionally, there's a need for policy reform. The government must address the gaps in wildlife management and human-wildlife conflict resolution. This includes strengthening the enforcement of conservation laws, improving habitat management, and ensuring that the voices of rural communities are heard and acted upon in policy discourse.

In conclusion, while community forestry has been a boon for Nepal's forests, it has inadvertently fueled a crisis threatening the livelihoods of rural communities. The path forward requires a collaborative approach involving CFUGs, FECOFUN, local governments, policymakers, and conservation bodies. The situation in Lamachaur and across Nepal, where "monkey terrorism" looms large, is a stark reminder of the delicate balance between conservation and human livelihoods.

(The author is pursuing a Ph.D. at the Department of Forestry and Environmental Resources, North Caroline State University, USA.)

In The Winds Of Time



Persijs Muznieks



"Culture is an inexhaustible mountain river that brings more and more new knowledge, whose value will be appreciated by the next generation." Sitting by the fire in these wet winter days, watching its boisterous dance, my memories flash back to the day I met Ramanand Tiwari. I don't know what a magical force brought us together, but at the meeting, after exchanging a few words, I realised that we have something in common. In front of me stood a small white-bearded god who blessed me with a shower of fragrant flowers over my head. This is how I remember him at Pilgrims Publishing House, Varanasi.

Every story has a beginning. When, as a journalist, the winds of work blew me away to work in Russia, I happened to meet a Siberian shaman named Karagai Kam and Iliya Smolin. There comes a period in everyone's life when ignorance about the future leads to despair. The existing situation created a favourable environment for reaching out for a helping hand.

"You will meet a small, white-clothed bearded man older than you..... You will have to cross the river (difficulties), and then everything will change..." Those were the words of a Siberian shaman, which, in a fateful turn, came true. A year later, when I met him on the streets of Kathmandu, I remembered what he had said about the bearded man—that fate had brought us together. It was the first time in my life when, overwhelmed by the uncertainty of the future, I turned to a shaman for help.

That very day, when I met Mr. Ramanand at Pilgrims Publishing House, the prophecy of Karagai suddenly dawned in my memory. In my thoughts, I joined on the trip, which, in the true sense of the word, would correspond to the name of the bookstore, Pilgrims.

The huge treasure of knowledge collected by Ramanand's own hands during decades of travel lies on the shelves of bookstores in Kathmandu and Varanasi. It must be said frankly that any visitor will find a topic suitable for his taste, such as esoteric sciences, anthropology, history, astronomy, religions, anatomy, political economy, architecture, and so on. Art of various genres and even specific topics such as health, Ayurveda, and the intimate world.

The interest does not pass by antiques arranged in a thematic sequence with books that enrich the overall calorie content and to which the bookstore employees pay special attention. The first floor is like an exhibition hall, which, with the background of baroque music, invites the visitor to separate himself from the noisy everyday life, pick up a book, and immerse himself in thought.

It is a real pleasure for everyone who visits here. The Guest Book evidences numerous expressions of gratitude, exceeding dozens in number. Words of thanks from all corners of the world rain down like a mountain spring.

... I have finally found the book I have been looking for a long time...

... it is a wonderful repository of knowledge...

... kind employees do not refuse to help...

There is an employee named Sunil who has been working in the bookstore since its early days. Ramanand's daughters, Elizabet and Kahani, with their father's care, have created a real world of attraction in the very centre of Kathmandu. The influx of more and more new people into the bookstore causes true joy, indicating that interest in books has not disappeared.

And if you have a chance to meet Ramanand, the owner of Pilgrims Book House, then he will embody the spark of joy for you and will actively engage in various topics under the influence of fragrant coffee.

The traditions of ancestors still live in the consciousness of Nepalis, who thank each guest for his visit. This respectful gesture is shown at the entrance of the bookstore by the entire Pilgrims Book House team.

January 22, 2024, was a special occasion for the bookstore in Nepal and possibly the whole world, as a new book, SANATANI RAMA, by Vivekanand Jha, was released. It is a journey through past civilizations, presenting the main theme in chronological order, which in the course of history comes up with a vivid comparison in the fields of politics, economy, and religion.

The author has put his thoughts in a book. An epochal insight from different points of view. Not everyone is clear about Sanatani, whose history can be traced centuries back. It is the forgetting of ancient civilizations whose cradle of wisdom continues to move, reminding future generations where we come from, as a starting point, and who we are. In the cross-section of the era, the Sanatani period, with a gap of many centuries, could be compared with African prehistoric religions such as Aksumites, Woodoos, Numibians, and Mazgabaz.

In Scandinavia, as well as in the Baltic countries and in Europe, it was so-called paganism, or darkness, when idolatry was practiced, for which the most suitable term would be piety rather than religion.

All pagan and other religious countries united under a common motto: "maintaining a strict relationship with nature." The force of nature and the ancient man living in harmony formed a common synthesis. The new religions, influenced by various selfish interests, have moved away from reality and have created irreparable harm by deliberately distorting originality. It would be wrong to deny that all religions have their origins in paganism and piety.

Vivekanand, in his book, gives an indirect hint to India and the youth of the whole world about where the answer is to be found. Is it self-identification or patriotism? The book has powerful words and a flow of thoughts. Continuing his thoughts, the author reminds us that the upcoming event is historically significant for India.

Little wonder then that the historic occasion of January 22, 2024, is the rediscovery of its moorings and its civilization soul, which eluded Sanatanis for almost five hundred years, as the author says. "If your first love was a book, then love it for ever." This motto has the magical allure of addictive power.

(Persijs, a press photographer from Finland, is studying the culture and costumes of Nepal.)

Staying Safe From Dangers Of Technology



Kanti Neupane



> It is necessary to chart a path where technology is ethically harnessed, ensuring that its positive impact exceeds its drawbacks.

A few days ago, while attending a meeting with IT experts, one of my friends suddenly asked a question: What would happen if Google and Facebook were closed forever? Her question drew everyone's attention. It was naive and unexpected. The government has been gearing up to create a paperless office, but it also threatens the tradition of writing and keeping documents.

This scribe has a habit of jotting important anecdotes down in notebooks. But now I write everything on laptops and mobile screens or post on social networking sites. I also wonder how our lives would change if Facebook and Google pages were turned off. The experts had their own arguments on these hypothetical queries. Some argued that Facebook or other social sites would not be deactivated, but others insisted that people's lives were increasingly becoming insecure due to the rise of social media fuelled by new technology. It has not only increased the possibility of theft or loss of confidential data, but it also offers various safety measures to avoid these risks. Technology expert Sarah Johnson warns that users face continuous risks of privacy breaches, surveillance, and data misuse. It is necessary to take effective measures to check for data breaches and financial fraud.

Renowned IT expert John Doe said, "Complexity is inherent in technology, but it is our ability to harness and manage that complexity that determines success." This requires understanding the intricacies of emerging technologies, their interdependencies, and the impact they have on multiple facets of operations, he added. Tech companies and IT wizards have had a profound impact on various aspects of our lives, from social networking and entertainment to search engines and productivity tools. The new technology has provided people with easy access to information. Their creations have contributed to the development and widespread adoption of innovative technologies and platforms that have transformed the way we communicate, access information, and interact with the digital world. They have also come under scrutiny, with debates surrounding privacy concerns, ethical considerations, and the influence of digital platforms on society.

Detrimental impacts

The prevalence of smartphones, social media, and virtual interactions often supplants meaningful face-to-face interactions, resulting in feelings of loneliness, disconnection, and reduced empathy. Psychologist John Smith emphasises that excessive screen time and constant exposure to digital media can have detrimental effects on our mental well-being. Increased reliance on technology has been associated with higher rates of anxiety, depression, and sleep disturbances. The culture of comparison, cyberbullying, and the addictive nature of social media platforms further exacerbate mental health. Therefore, the emerging technology has not only facilitated human life, but it has also increased the risk of controlling information systems and narratives by a few tech firms that operate major software companies and social networking sites.

The most common risks of new technologies are data breaches, leakage of private and confidential information, software vulnerabilities, interoperability issues, online harassment, identity theft, and an erosion of trust in the digital realm. New technology has been abused to commit fraud, character assassination, emotional blackmail, and harassment. According to the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Centre, USA, cybercrime caused economic losses worth over $4 billion in 2020, with a surge in ransomware attacks and phishing scams. This data highlights the pervasive nature of cybercrime and its significant impact on the economy. Data analysis from the World Economic Forum states that cybercrime costs the global economy an estimated $1 trillion annually. This financial burden severely impacts businesses and governments, hindering economic growth and stability.

"Cybercrime is impacting businesses of all sizes, and any business that wants to ensure its uptime, its reputation, and the safety of its employee and customer data has a responsibility to invest in cybersecurity and put themselves ahead of disruption," Erin McLean, chief marketing officer at eSentire, told Cybercrime Magazine. Research conducted by the Identity Theft Resource Centre reveals that in 2020 alone, there were over 1.4 million reported cases of identity theft in the United States alone. The growing accumulation and retention of personal data by corporations and institutions has raised concerns about privacy and data security.

It is imperative to prioritise safeguarding privacy and guaranteeing the security of data for the well-being of individuals, businesses, and governments alike.

Confidential data leakage

These days developed countries are also facing great challenges from new technology. When personal and government secret information is leaked to the public, the state feels a security threat. In Nepal, too, government websites are frequently hacked and closed for a long time. As a result, there is a fear that the government's confidential data may get into the hands of hackers. Some time ago, anonymous hackers attacked the official website of the Institute of Science and Technology (IoST), Tribhuvan University, and posted content entitled 'Justice for Sandip LC' on it. They had apparently sought justice for cricketer Sandeep Lamichhane, who is currently in judicial custody over a rape charge. The number of victims, who have complained that hackers have withdrawn millions of rupees from their personal bank accounts, is also growing significantly.

Technology has undoubtedly brought about a sea change in the lives of people, but it is crucial to critically evaluate its impacts on society. With the evolution of cutting-edge information technology, there is a decline in social bonds, negative effects on mental health, privacy loss, economic disruption, and environmental degradation. These consequences can be tackled through collaboration among individuals, corporations, and the government. It is necessary to chart a path where technology is ethically harnessed, ensuring that its positive impact exceeds its drawbacks.

(Neupane is associated with Nepal Television.)

Paradigm Shift In Gender Stereotyte



Dr. Sumit Kumar Pathak

> Pink Mountains are not only promoting tourism but also fostering connections and understanding between different cultures.

Nepal recently legalised same-sex marriage, breaking traditional norms and promoting inclusivity. This sparked debates on religion and conservatism, pitting personal freedom against traditional beliefs. LGBTQI+ advocates, like Sunil Babu Pant, played a crucial role in shaping public opinion. Their efforts aim to make Nepal a leader in LGBTQI+ rights in Asia. Nepal's acceptance of same-sex unions is linked to its democratic values. In 2007, the Supreme Court in Pant v. Nepal ruled that being gender non-conforming or having same-sex orientation is natural, not a mental disorder.

The court emphasised that LGBTI identities are natural and recognised the right to privacy for all, including LGBTI individuals. It declared that penalising same-sex relations as "unnatural" goes against fundamental rights, stressing the importance of non-discrimination. Sunil Babu Pant's (founder of Blue Diamond Society) efforts, from local advocacy to international initiatives like Pink Mountains, showcase Nepal as a global advocate for LGBTQI+ rights. Pink Mountains reflects a commitment to providing a unique and welcoming experience for LGBTQI+ tourists.

The introduction of elaborate honeymoon packages showcases a nuanced understanding of the diverse needs within the LGBTQI+ community. The Pink Mountains are not only promoting tourism but also fostering connections and understanding between different cultures. The South Asia LGBT Sports Festival in 2012 and Pant's strategic use of the Gaijatra festival symbolise a shift from local struggles to a global cause. The country's courageous move to host Asia's first-ever sports tournament for the LGBTQI+ community in 2012 demonstrates Nepal's commitment to fostering inclusivity and challenging societal norms. Although Nepal's sexual orientation and gender identity (SOGI) activism initially lagged behind that of its neighbour India, the country demonstrated exceptional courage by hosting Asia's inaugural sports tournament.





The South Asia LGBT Sports Festival, organised by the Blue Diamond Society at the national stadium in Kathmandu, marked a significant milestone and showcased Nepal's commitment to inclusivity. The internationalisation of this march reflects the interconnectedness of global LGBTQI+ communities, emphasising the shared goals of equality, acceptance, and the celebration of love irrespective of gender identity or sexual orientation.

As a strategic and symbolic move, Pant leveraged the Gaijatra festival, a traditional Nepali event known for its celebration of diversity, satire, and remembrance of those who have passed away during the year. Pant saw this festival as an opportune moment to challenge societal norms and prejudices by creating a platform for sexual minorities to "come out" and assert their presence in public spaces. By intertwining this traditional celebration with the modern struggle for LGBTQI+ rights, it aims to bridge generational and cultural gaps, demonstrating that acceptance and celebration of diversity are values that can coexist with longstanding traditions.

In an ice-breaking move, Nepal is making strides towards inclusivity by allowing transgender contestants like Angel Lama to participate in its national pageant. This progressive step makes Nepal only the third country in Asia, after Myanmar and Mongolia, to embrace the inclusion of transgender individuals in their esteemed national pageants.

Angel Lama's presence as a finalist in the Miss Universe Nepal competition is not merely a personal achievement but a broader societal shift towards recognising and celebrating diversity. While Nepal's decision to allow transgender contestants is a commendable step forward, it also highlights the need for more countries to embrace similar inclusivity.

Redefining freedom

The marriage between Surendra Pandey and Maya Gurung exemplifies a paradigm shift in societal attitudes. Recognising same-sex marriage as an extension of the democratic principle of "freedom of choice" challenges historical prejudices and expands personal autonomy. Drawing on philosophers like Isaiah Berlin and John Stuart Mill, the argument emphasises that protecting sexual liberties is essential for societal progress and should transcend cultural biases.

Isaiah Berlin asserted in 1969 that the essence of freedom lies in minimising interference, stating, "The wider the area of non-interference, the wider my freedom." Moreover, within the framework of a democracy, sexual liberties are integral to individual rights and must be zealously protected. The idea that democracy is a developmental phenomenon takes on new meaning when we recognise that safeguarding sexual liberties is essential for societal progress. John Stuart Mill's timeless assertion, dating back to 1859, remains pertinent: "The only purpose for which power can be rightfully exercised over any member of a civilised community, against his will, is to prevent harm to others." Additionally, in the context of the developing world, where cultural norms often play a dominant role, it becomes imperative to shield sexual liberties from becoming victims of cultural bias.

Recent developments

Nepal's historic move on November 29, 2023, in Dordi Rural Municipality to officially register a same-sex marriage, following the Supreme Court's directive, establishes it as a pioneer in South Asia. On June 27, 2023, Nepal's Supreme Court issued an interim order, a pivotal decree that paved the way for the registration of same-sex marriages. This legal advancement was a significant leap forward in acknowledging and affirming the rights of the LGBTQI+ community. However, the journey for Pandey and Gurung was not without obstacles. The involvement of the judiciary reflects a commitment to equality and nondiscrimination.

Despite India's recent Supreme Court verdict on October 16, 2023, a five-judge bench of the Supreme Court of India announced a 3:2 verdict on petitions seeking the rights of members of the LGBTQ community to marry and choose family. The Court declined to legalise same-sex marriage, placing it upon the Parliament and province governments to decide if non-heterosexual unions can be legally recognised, while Nepal's journey emphasises the ongoing pursuit of full inclusivity, blending legal initiatives with societal evolution.

Nepal's trajectory towards recognising and legally sanctioning same-sex marriages is a testament to the delicate interplay of tradition, democracy, and tireless activism. While legal milestones are crucial, societal acceptance remains a challenge. Legal reforms must complement their success with genuine cultural and societal acceptance.

(The author is an assistant professor of the Department of Political Studies at the Central University of South Bihar.)

Deciphering Love



Saudamini Chalise



"I belong to no religion. My religion is 'Love'. My heart is my temple."
- Rumi

> Love isn't without flaws; it does have its dark side, like everything else in the world. Love itself doesn't equal compatibility; only love doesn't solve problems, and love isn't always worth sacrificing.

With Valentine's Day around the corner and all the hullaballoo on love, cupid's humdrum, and rushing passion through the veins akin to raging hormones, among all the concocted notions on love are the compromises of various facets of love: infatuation, puppy love, romantic love, empty love, compassionate love, fatuous love, and so on. Love is a constant ebb and flow of emotions towards a particular person. Having a soft corner for someone, falling hook, line, and sinker for someone exhibiting emotional melodrama normally manages to tiptoe in the lives of most people across the world.

However, love isn't without flaws; it does have its dark side, like everything else in the world. Love itself doesn't equal compatibility; only love doesn't solve problems, and love isn't always worth sacrificing.

The early stages of intense romantic love or intense crush, being obsessed with someone, heart aches, and emotional topsy-turvy can also create havoc on human health. The mere thought of someone special or a picture of people whom we love releases 'happy hormones', spreading the feel-good factor.

From intense emotional drama to sweet romantic gestures, it's all about the highs and lows of love. Only genuine love is a perfect equation; it is that mixture of perfect chemistry that forms an unconditional relationship.

Love apparently has its own language, i.e., a language used to express emotional feelings with one's partner. Various other factors, like culture, social motif, emotional health, social upbringing, etc., seem to affect love and the expression of emotions.

Love is almost similar, or rather matches the attributes, like a pea in a pod with gardening, as the love that isn't nurtured gradually fades away.

Love is that faint string that holds the fragile cord of the human world. Irrespective of the glorified versions of romantic love, it isn't devoid of agony, emotional meltdowns, disconnections, etc. Love is also like a weird blend of intimate vulnerability and a threat of emotional isolation. Relationships play an important role in human lives since they are like part of our survival code.

Love, dating, building a relationship, nurturing trust, kindling attachment, and marriage are all the two sides of a coin in retrospect to human relations. Love is a universal language and shouldn't be subjugated to represent only physically intimate love; it must be fathomed and appreciated on a much wider spectrum, and it also encompasses other aspects of our mundane human lives such as compassion, kindness, a feeling of genuine concern for fellow humans, concerns for the nation, self-love, etc. Even on an emotional and mental level, a person shouldn't remain that vulnerable, helpless, and dependent on anyone's love; no one should be hooked on the mercy of someone else's emotional or physical presence in their lives, as being addicted in such a manner destroys emotional and mental sanctity.

In today's context, love also seems to have undergone some thorough rejigging as the 'World' is facing utter chaos and catastrophe across the world: economic recession, the aftermath of pandemics, sociopolitical turmoil, natural disasters, the expansion of territories in Gaza and Ukraine, and inhumane activities across the world. Love and compassion should be used to mellowing down social apathy and social indifference to build bridges that foster social alliances rather than building a wall.

It isn't the innate nature of 'love' to build a 'wall' and remain a fiddle to a few. Love is the spark that ignites even the darkest of hearts. It opens out the heart for weaving out a more vigilant social circle that remains compassionate and empathetic towards other people in general.

People should ignite such love in their hearts that they can comprehend every beating heart in the neighbourhood, city, region, country, and world and understand that every heart beats, aches, and bleeds like theirs.

If only the cold and callous hearts could sense the silent cries and helplessness, then perhaps no one in our entire world would have to remain homeless, remain with an empty stomach, or suffer the pangs of poverty at the hands of a ruthless world and become deprived of education, warm food, and compassion. No elderly's tear would cascade down the fold of their wrinkled faces if only 'Love' surpassed everything. No woman across the world would have sold and bought in a flesh market akin to objects if only the ethos of universal love would come across.

On the contrary to the essence and attributes of 'love', people in general are seen to understand differently and fall in and out of'superficial love' more swiftly than use and throw objects.

'Love' epitomised by Rumi, Omar Khayyam, Ferdowsi, and Khalil Gibran tends to touch the soul and essence of humanity; its more tends towards mysticism rather than objectifying love of flesh, understood more by common rabbles and gulps down. The capsule of love like cocaine-addicted junkies.

(The author is a writer and holds a Ph.D. in travel and tourism.)

FUTURE WATCH

(Based on birth names)

February 9th to 15th, 2024 - D. N. Lohani

ARIES
A high level of enthusiasm will drive you ahead. Regular gains will help consolidate your financial position. Don't expect much support from your family. The expenditure level will rise during the second half. You will experience a busy schedule.

TAURUS
Despite prevailing fear and confusion, circumstances will gradually improve. Undertaken assignments will be completed successfully. Study will take a progressive course. Foreign travel can occur. Expenditure levels can rise on Thursday.

GEMINI
Start is ordinary. Success without struggle is unlikely. Circumstances will improve tomorrow. Opponents will remain active. Trade and profession will both turn profitable.

CANCER
You may have to tackle numerous obstacles. A health disorder is predicted. Family and medical expenses can rise. Business-related travel can arise. Study will take a progressive course.

LEO
Travel is in store for you. Business can slow down. Opponents will remain active, but their conspiracy will fail. Study will take a progressive course. A health disorder can increase expenses.

VIRGO
Undertaken assignments will be completed successfully. You will find it difficult to control expenses. Employees may hear good news. Investments will generate returns. Writing skills will improve. Avoid risky ventures on Thursday.

LIBRA
Health-related expenses can rise during the initial period. Circumstances will improve starting Monday. Family and relatives will provide good support. Minor injuries can cause concern.

SCORPIO
A health disorder is predicted. Success without struggle is unlikely. You will receive good support from your siblings. Students will have to work harder. Employees may face challenges.

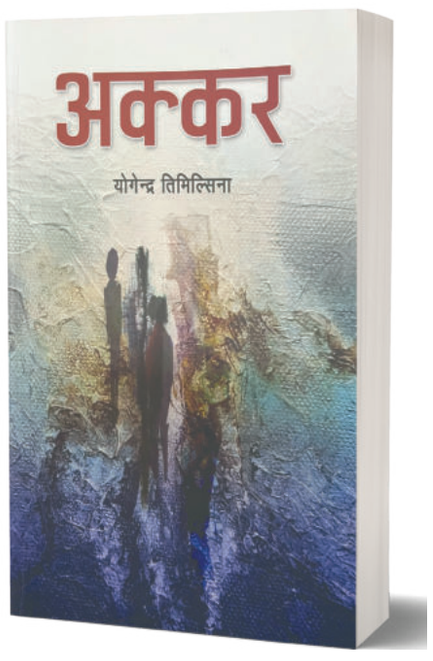
SAGITTARIUS
Handle valuable goods cautiously on Friday. Circumstances will improve tomorrow. Study will take a progressive course. You may have to face pain on the maternal side. Avoid minor injuries on Tuesday.

CAPRICORN
Celebrations or similar events can occur and are likely to increase expenses. Trade and profession will both turn profitable. Friends and family will provide appreciable support.

AQUARIUS
Expenditure will surpass income. Studying will keep you busy. Business will continue as usual. The family will increase expenses. Employees will remain dissatisfied with their progress.

PISCES
An advantageous week is in the store. Income and expenditure will maintain balance. Trade and profession will both turn profitable. Study will take a progressive course. The family will cooperate when required.

A Mirror Of Social Problem



BOOK REVIEW



Gandhi Raj Kafle

Akkar (Rock), a novel in Nepali, by Yogendra Timilsina, published by Oriental Publication House, Kathmandu, price: 250.00, ISBN: 978 – 9937 – 722 – 91 – 9.

In one bitter parlance, the life of man has been defined as rock. This perception seems to be true because life is hard. Yet amidst this perception of difficulty, there exists a counterbalance in an inspiring saying, offering hope and resilience. Those who liken life to a rock also emphasise the indomitable human spirit. They urge everyone to turn challenges into opportunities for a meaningful life.

Therefore, the question in the context of the under-reviewed Nepali novel entitled "Akkar" by Yogendra Timilsina is: Is the story Akkar representative of the contemporary emotions of our lives? The issue is serious because it demands soul-searching rather than measuring the successes of life by the mess of physical achievement.

In fact, the problem is there, as described by this novel, because the characters in it have not been able to feel love, comfort, and consolation, even with lifelong honest labour and successes. Is it a dominant trend in Nepali society?

The novelist Timilsina's main and other supportive characters appear from humble backgrounds, and through them, stories of life develop.

Finally, all the characters in the novel encounter a grave situation at the vulnerable stage of old age.

Is it not social chaos? Novelist Timilsina mirrors the story prominently through the lives of the hard-working couple Dev Raj and Babita.

Why do they reach a frustrating situation despite so many struggles and progress? This question, in fact, is crucial from the point of view of other minor characters in the novel, like Basanta, Smarika, Bikash, and Aradhana.

Generally, readers of the novel should expect 'all should be well' for honest, laborious, and hard-working characters like Dev Raj and Babita.

But "Akkar" does not meet this wish because it finds the growth of an unhealthy trend uncontrollable, and families are passing through new troubles. These new troubles stem from specific causes.

Society's overemphasis on materialism and the youth's indifference towards moral education are fueling a growing disrespect for elders in today's generation. How can honest characters like Dev Raj and Babita churn out happy lives out of their lifetime fruits of hard work? This question is like "Akkar," or rock, for Dev Raj in the novel.

While talking about social aberrations, Dev Raj's feelings are worth mentioning. He questions astonishingly, 'If we live our lives with the nature of animals, there can't be any value in human beings for us' (page 79 in the novel). The novelist Timilsina is also bitter about the misuse of social media.

He warns in the novel, 'The chance of today's youths becoming depressed is very high because they are prone to watching sexually unhealthy materials on social media like Facebook and YouTube since childhood, and the impact of all these activities is that their marriage life is either breaking or becoming unstable' (page 100).

The author of the novel "Akkar" is distinctly elaborative, even in praise of the beauty of nature.

In fact, the author is backed up to sharpen his descriptive mood by his travel experiences in all three prominent geographical regions of the country: hills, terai, and valleys.

The story of this novel itself begins with a beautiful description of Dhankuta and its surroundings.

Then, things of beauty figure from the Eastern Terai of Nepal, especially Morang and Jhapa districts, as characters move from one place to another with the aim of making progress in life. The novel finally settles on a description of the sprawling settlements of the Kathmandu Valley because Timilsina's main character finally lands here to fulfil their dream of happy living.

In fact, Yogendra Timilsina holds a deep interest in contributing to Nepali literature.

The proof is his publications, because it has not been long since this fresh novel, "Akkar," was published. He has had a good publication of the collection of short biographies of the world-famous litterateurs entitled "Renowned Litterateurs of the World," 2078 BS.

The other Nepali novels to remember in this regard are Punarmilan (Reunion), Phul Ra Kanda (Flower and Thorn), and Antyahin Yaatra (Travel Beyond End).

In conclusion, he is also the writer who published a collection of Nepali stories entitled "Baisako Nirwasit Shahar" (Banished City of Young Lover) forty-five years ago, in 2034 BS.

Since then and coming now, the themes and times have both witnessed sea change. Are all these changes all good? Worries and challenges to look at as a man of creativity for Timilsina are enormous. So, the novel "Akkar" can be taken as a genuine story from a mature author.

Rising Hope In Nepali Cricket



Nayak Poudel

With every big step Nepal's cricket team has taken over the years, millions of Nepalis have found one more reason to unite for a common joyful moment. And this year, Nepal's cricket fraternity has more to cheer about than ever.

Moreover, Nepal's cricket fraternity's expectations from the national cricket teams have never been higher than now. The U19 men's team recently defeated Afghanistan, a test-playing nation, in the ICC U19 World Cup group stage and became the only associate team to qualify for the Super Six. In a hard-fought extended journey in South Africa, Nepalis cheered the youngsters for an admirable performance despite losing two more matches in the campaign against Bangladesh and India in the Super Six.

Nepal's women's national team will also be cheered immensely as they compete in the ACC Women's Premier Cup, which kicks off on February 10 in Malaysia. The Rhino Army hopes Nepal wins the T20 tournament as only three of the 16 teams—Thailand, the UAE, and Indonesia—rank not so high above the women's team in the ICC's ranking.

Nevertheless, Nepal playing in the ICC T20 World Cup in June will be the biggest event for cricket fans. As it is not the first time Nepal is qualifying for a cricket World Cup, Nepali cricket fans now hope to see the country defeating top teams, which is impossible with the current squad and infrastructure.

Identifying new talents and providing opportunities is key to building a strong national team. This may mean replacing underperforming players. However, improving their performance through effective training and mentorship is essential. Organising ample domestic leagues facilitates these activities.

For instance, new talents and players who have not been called into the national team for quite some time outperformed active national team players in the sixth edition of the PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament.

New talents

The sixth edition of the PM Men's Cup ended on February 3, with 46 matches played across 21 days at three venues. Nepal Police Club was crowned champions, defeating Tribhuwan Army Club by six wickets in the finals.

Whenever there was at least one departmental side playing, a decent crowd was visible in the respective venue, eager to watch senior team players perform. Those playing for the national men's cricket team are mostly associated with a departmental side—Nepal Police Club, Armed Police Force (APF) Club, and Tribhuwan Army Club—in domestic cricket.

The senior team's latest matches were played in the ICC Men's T20 World Cup Asia Qualifier as Nepal hosted seven countries—Oman, Malaysia, Singapore, UAE, Bahrain, Hong Kong, and Kuwait—for a spot in the T20 World Cup in June 2024. In the qualifiers, players like Kushal Bhurtel, Aasif Sheikh, Rohit Paudel, Dipendra Singh Airee, Kushal Malla, Bibek Yadav, Karan KC, Sompal Kami, Abinash Bohora, and Sundeep Jora showcased their skills. However, they were overshadowed by domestic players during the PM Cup. Additionally, players outside the current senior national team clinched all three individual awards—best bowler, best batsman, and best player of the tournament.

On the bowling side, Bagmati's slow left-arm orthodox Surya Tamang was the highest wicket-taker with 30 wickets in nine matches. Tamang was also the 'best player' of the tournament. He was followed by Sudur Pashchim's Sher Malla (right-arm off-break) with 24 wickets in nine matches.

On the other hand, the second-highest scorer in the tournament was Ashutosh Ghiraiya, who was adjudged the emerging player of the tournament in Bagmati Province. Ghiraiya, who captained Lalitpur district's team in Bagmati's selection for the PM Cup, scored 382 runs in nine matches.

Anil Kumar Sah, who represented Madhes Province, was the best batsman, as he scored the most runs in the tournament (386 runs in nine matches). Sah, who debuted for the national team against the Netherlands in 2018, has not received his call to wear the national jersey after playing against Papua New Guinea in 2022.

Regarding batting, Pawan Sharaf (Madhes) was the fourth and final batsman to score over 300 runs in the tournament. He scored 329 runs in nine matches with three half-centuries. Sharaf has represented Nepal in the U19 and senior stages, with his last match against the UAE in the ACC Men's Emerging Cup in 2023.

Except for two active internationals, Sundeep Jora and Aasif Sheikh, Binod Bhandari, who last played for Nepal against the Maldives at the Asian Games in 2023, hit two centuries in the tournament. Bhandari was the third-highest scorer overall, with 351 runs.

Anil, Ashutosh, Mayan Yadav (Madhes), Naren Bhatta (Sudur Pashchim), Sujan Thapaliya (Koshi), and Rashid Khan (Police) also hit a century each.

In the case of senior team bowlers, Sompal Kami, Karan KC, and Abinash Bohora bagged 34 wickets in total, only four more than Surya Tamang alone.

Active internationals at PM Men's Cup 2024			
Name	Matches (bat innings)	Runs	Wickets
Rohit Paudel	9(9)	273	14
Arjun Saud	10(10)	268	
Kushal Malla	10(10)	246	15
Aasif Sheikh	6(6)	204	
Aarif Sheikh	9(8)	256	
Sundeep Jora	9(8)	185	
Dipendra Singh Airee	9(6)	165	15
Kushal Bhurtel	9(9)	163	6
Bibek Yadav	10(9)	132	7
Sompal Kami	10(6)	102	19
Karan KC	10(5)	86	10
Abinash Bohora	3(2)	26	5

New talents and inactive internationals at PM Men's Cup 2024			
Name	Matches (bat innings)	Runs	Wickets
Anil Kumar Sah	9(9)	386	
Ashutosh Ghiraiya	9(9)	382	
Binod Bhandari	10(9)	351	
Pawan Sarraf	9(9)	329	
Mayan Yadav	9(9)	287	
Kiran Thagunna	9(8)	284	
Lalit Narayan Rajbanshi	10(4)	7	23
Surya Tamang	9(6)	48	30
Sher Malla	9(8)	98	24
Shahab Alam	10(6)	52	23
Bipin Khatri	9(9)	92	20
Rijan Dhakal	9(7)	20	15



Positive signs

Despite criticism of Nepal's cricket authorities for failing to recruit quality players and adequately train struggling ones, Nepali cricket fans have noticed positive changes.

After the conclusion of the PM Men's Cup on February 3, the Cricket Association of Nepal announced two squads—one for a bilateral series against Canada and the other for ICC League 2 matches against Namibia and the Netherlands. These squads have been praised for including talented players who performed well in the PM Cup.

Anil Kumar Sah, Surya Tamang, Pawan Sarraf, and Rijan Dhakal have been selected for the national team based on their performances in the domestic league. Their performance in the series against Canada, with Pawan, Surya, and Rijan also featuring in the ICC League 2 matches, will certainly be watched over.

> If the government had fulfilled even half of its promises for the cricket sector, Nepal would have better infrastructure by now.

While the performance of these new faces on the global stage remains to be seen, integrating fresh talent is a trend crucial for the team's improvement.

The release of a calendar for domestic and international matches in 2024, the organised scheduling of events, and adherence to declared timings highlight the newfound responsibility of the Cricket Association of Nepal (CAN).

Current problems

If the government had fulfilled even half of its promises for the cricket sector, Nepal would have better infrastructure by now. For example, recent assurances to install floodlights at the TU International Cricket Ground in Kirtipur have been delayed due to administrative glitches.

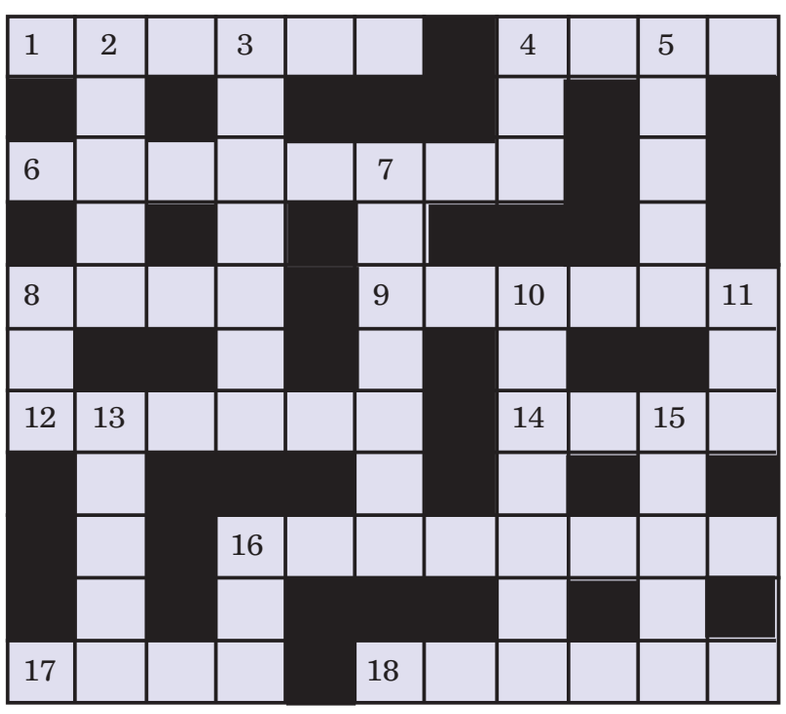
While some are pleased that the Bagmati Province government allocated a budget to cover 70 per cent of the cost to make the Gautam Buddha International Cricket Stadium in Chitwan playable with a parapet for 10,000 viewers, past government inaction has lowered expectations among Nepali cricket fans.

The delay in reimbursing prize money to players over the years shows how easily government representatives make promises they can't keep. Political interference and favouritism at provincial and district levels have hindered the sector's progress, with recent conflicts in player selection for the PM Men's Cup raising questions.

Cricket has brought the country together with a common dream, but the neglect from authorities has saddened millions of fans.

(The author is a journalist at The Rising Nepal.)

TRN CROSSWORD PUZZLE NO. 1777



Name .....

Address .....

Signature .....

Last date of entry:
February 14, 2024

Win a prize of Rs. 600. In case there are more than one correct entry the prize will be split into three sums of Rs. 200 each. The winner will be selected by a lucky draw. Only cuttings (not photo copy) that include the Crossword Puzzle no. will be accepted.

Across

1. An epic poem
4. Not lacking anything
6. Aggressive and hungry
8. Opposed to
9. Printed message
12. Good at public speech
14. As soon as possible
16. Debts not likely to be paid (3, 5)
17. Block a hole
18. Machines for drying

Down

2. Easy to understand
3. Indicate in advance
4. A state of bewilderment
5. Go away from
7. Badly behaved
8. Immediately
10. Very sad event
11. Tear suddenly
13. Drive attackers away
15. Performer in film
16. Annoy your friend

Solutions to TRN Crossword Puzzle No. 1776

ACROSS: 1. STATUS 4. PACT 6. CLEMENCY 8. MEAL 9. SIMPLE 12. PATROL 14. MEND 16. DISSOLVE 17. PLAN 18. SPHERE

DOWN: 2. TULLE 3. TUMBLER 4. PAY 5. CAVIL 7. NESTLES 8. MAP 10. MAMMOTH 11. END 13. AWFUL 15. NEVER 16. DON

LUCKY WINNER

Abhijeet Rajopadhyaya
Sheela Shrestha
Krishna Chandra Gautam

ALL CORRECT ANSWER

Rekha Rajopadhyaya, Damodar Lohani, Bal Krishna Shrestha, Archana Devi Shrestha, Kumari Nirmala Giri, Khagendra Nath, Mahendra Kumari Nath, Mana Raja Rajopadhyaya, Sunil Sharma Bhattarai

CREATIVE CORNER

If I Were A Son Of A Billionaire



Prabin Rai

Perhaps, if I were the son of a billionaire I would be a millionaire, my every wish would be fulfilled; every need shall repent by fancy things.

And I would have to get a better education, my lifestyle would be aristocracy, every little wants and dreams may come true but I am just the son of a grower; who barely manage to breathe a peaceful parcel.

However, I wouldn't be so simple, inspired by tiny thoughts which has many desirous pain hidden inside the deep dark cerebrum and heart; my heart may not speak to the darkness is what makes it dark.

Finally, if I were the son of a billionaire, I would be a perfect guy but not a perfect son, a wealthy man but not healthy, every light has its own luminous that brightens up every little fancy thing.



Abhimandan Upreti, Grade: II, ASIA Pacific School, Dhapasi

TRN PUZZLE NUMBER-409

All you have to do is to fill up in the seven boxes below with the numbers in such a way that the sum will be 623 whether you go diagonally, horizontally or vertically. The numbers should be 65 to 113 between. The number should not be used twice.

94	103	112	65	74	83	92
102		71		82		93
110		72		90		101
69		80		98		109
77		88		106		68
85		96		107		76
86	95	104	113	66	75	84

57	66	75	28	37	46	55
65	74	34	36	45	54	56
73	33	35	44	53	62	64
32	41	43	52	61	63	72
40	42	51	60	69	71	31
48	50	59	68	70	30	39
49	58	67	76	29	38	47

TRN PUZZLE SOLUTION-408

Prepared by: Bishwo Nath Kharel

My Trip To Philadelphia



Vidheha Ranjan

I am on a family trip to Philadelphia. We wanted to walk around the waterfront but there wasn't any parking left so we decided to go to the Independence National Historical Park. We parked underground and as we emerged on the road using an elevator, we climbed onto a grassy clearing, from there we saw the Independence Hall!

My grandmother was with us on this trip and told me all the things she knew about the Independence Hall and more. The Independence Hall is where the United States declared its independence. Philadelphia was the first the capital of the United States, the capital was moved to Washington DC later.

My dad booked tickets for us to tour the Independence Hall at three o'clock. While we waited, we went to a museum next to the clearing. We saw the Independence Bell which was big and cracked.

An early hand printing press was impressive. It was not mechanical: two leather balls with wooden handles were used to press writing on paper.

We saw pictures of important people that lived long ago and a basket of clothes that they wore which we could try on. That was fun! After that we saw a couple of halls where documentaries on the history of the Independence hall were playing. We took a photo with a Benjamin Franklin statue.

It was time to go to the Independence Hall. There was a guide to take us into the building. She was very friendly. The building looked pretty big from the outside with three floors, a clock and a huge bell at the top which rang loudly every hour. We were in a room where George Washington, Benjamin Franklin and Abraham Lincoln were among the people who worked here to launch democracy.

We visited the supreme court. This room was big and there were multiple chairs at the top for judges, tables for officials at the bottom, tables for courthouse staves and a witness stand. The guide explained to us what the room was for and how it was used.

The other room had a seat for the president of the United States (George Washington) at the top, and chairs and tables for the states at the bottom like Pennsylvania, Delaware, Massachusetts and many more.

After we finished the tour, we walked around the park outside. I tried to feed acorns to the squirrels and I can't believe one took them from me, I was so excited. This was the first time, a squirrel had taken something from my hand!

We walked here and there. My sister, Dad and I went to buy stuff, explore the streets and had fun! We walked back to our car when we saw an ice cream shop.... Tell me, WHO DOESN'T LIKE ICE CREAM? Hajurmua, Dad, Mom, my sister, and I all happily chose special and different flavors of which pecan was my favorite. The ice cream was really special, I hope to go back there again for more, it was very expensive though.



Then we visited a very local Philly Sandwich place and enjoyed the food and drinks. The sandwiches were huge and super tasty.

Because all of us were tired from walking and walking, we went somewhere where we could sit. My dad found out that the riverfront was not far from us so we went there. The river was huge! WOW there were so many ships, I mean the big ones.

At the sides of the sidewalk were fun things like swings, huge sculptures, hammocks and there were 2 huge swans shaped like a boat so we went in them and took pictures. There was also an enormous chair, maybe like 30 people could fit on it.

Behind all of that, there were old ships, warships of different kinds, and submarines and parts like the ship propellers and canons were on the sidewalk. Well, though we couldn't touch them, it was still very cool. Now this was also a museum area. One of the ships had been converted into a restaurant but, sadly, we did not go in, because we had already eaten.

People, if you are going to Philly, that's what they call Philadelphia, go to the Independence Hall, walk around and around like we did, go to the park, eat the special ice-cream, go to the riverfront, enjoy looking at the ships, and HAVE FUN!

I think the best part of this trip was... EVERYTHING!

(Grade V, Windy Hill Elementary.)